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STUDY COMPANION | DOCUMENT HVM-002-C

The Divine Mother Kali

Who She is, and our relationship with Her

काली भवतारिणी

Document number	**HVM-002-C** (Study Companion to slides HVM-002-S)
Class number	**HVM-002**, Hamilton Vedanta-Meditation monthly class (second in the series)
Date and time	Wednesday 4 November 2026, 6:30 to 8:00 pm NZDT, in the days before Diwali and Kali Puja (Sunday 8 November 2026)
Venue	Phoenix Community Hall, 22 Richmond St, Frankton, Hamilton, and online via Zoom
Presenter	Swami Tadananda, Minister-in-Charge, Ramakrishna Vedanta Centre
Contact	mail@vedanta.nz	www.vedanta.nz
Version	1.0, 31 October 2026. Companion slides: HVM-002-S (24 slides)

Each section shows one slide, the notes on it, key terms, commentary and the questions for reflection. All quotations in this companion were checked word for word against the Gospel of Sri Ramakrishna, the Gospel of Holy Mother and the Complete Works of Swami Vivekananda on 31 October 2026. Where a teaching comes from outside those three books, for example the symbolism of the tongue or the names of the four Shaktis, the text says so.

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HOW OUR DOCUMENTS ARE NUMBERED

Every class in the monthly series has a class number, **HVM-NNN** (Hamilton Vedanta-Meditation), assigned in order: HVM-002 is this class, the second in the series. Each document for that class carries the class number plus a letter for its type: **-S** for the slides and **-C** for the Study Companion. Within a document, slides and sections are numbered in order, so **HVM-002-S05** is slide 5 of the slides and **HVM-002-C05** is the matching section of this companion. Sub-headings inside a section are numbered 5.1, 5.2 and so on. Appendices are

HVM-002-C-A1, A2 and so on. When quoting or asking a question, please give the number, for example "HVM-002-C05, 5.3".

Devanagari verses follow the standard printed form with sandhi. The transliteration (IAST) beside each verse separates words for easier study.

Title



ON THE SLIDE

Diwali is near. On the new moon night of Kartik, Sunday 8 November 2026, the Divine Mother is worshipped as Kali. This class asks who She is and what our relationship with Her is, in the words of three people who knew Her: Sri Ramakrishna (1836 to 1886), Holy Mother Sri Sarada Devi (1853 to 1920) and Swami Vivekananda (1863 to 1902).

The image on the screen is Bhavatarini, the Divine Mother at the Kali temple in Dakshineswar, where Sri Ramakrishna served as priest from 1855. Later in the evening we will read this image detail by detail: Her dark colour, Her feet on Siva, the garland of heads, the sword and the tongue.

1.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Kālī / काली	the Divine Mother as the power of time and of all change; from kāla, time
Śakti / शक्ति	power or energy; the Divine as active
Bhavatāriṇī / भवतारिणी	She who takes one across the ocean of worldly existence; the name of the image at Dakshineswar
Dīpāvalī / दीपावली	the row of lamps; Diwali

1.2 WHAT THIS CLASS IS ABOUT

Diwali is near, and on the new moon night of Kartik the Divine Mother is worshipped as Kali. This class asks two questions. Who is this Divine Mother Kali? And what is our relationship with Her? The answers come from people who knew Her: Sri Ramakrishna, who worshipped Her at Dakshineswar and spoke with Her daily; Holy Mother Sri Sarada Devi, whom he worshipped as the Divine Mother Herself; and Swami Vivekananda, who fought the idea of Kali for six years and then accepted Her as the power behind the universe.

1.3 ONE THREAD THROUGH THE EVENING

The thread is a single question: whose lap am I sitting in? Vedanta answers that the power which has become this universe is not a stranger to us. She is the Mother, and we are Her

children. Everything else tonight, the philosophy, the image, the practices, hangs on that one relationship.

1.4 THE PICTURE ON THE SCREEN

The photograph is of Bhavatarini, the Divine Mother at the Kali temple in Dakshineswar on the Ganga, where Sri Ramakrishna was the priest from 1855. The same image he dressed, fed, sang to and argued with is the one we are looking at. Later in the evening we will read the image detail by detail.

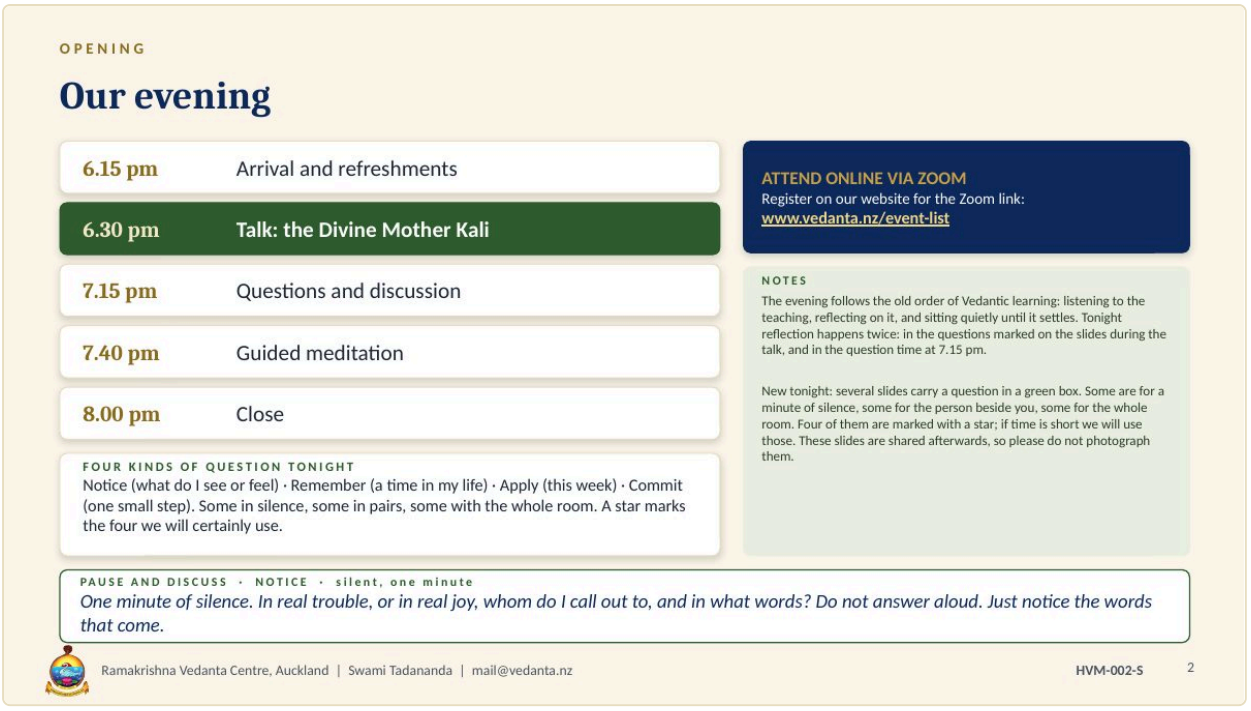
1.5 IS THIS CLASS ONLY FOR HINDUS, OR ONLY FOR BENGALIS?

No. The forms of worship described here grew in Bengal, and Swami Vivekananda was careful to say that Kali worship is not a necessary step in any religion. But the teaching behind the form is universal: that the power which has become this universe is not indifferent to us, that it can be approached as a mother, and that everything in our lives, pleasant and unpleasant, belongs to one Reality. Nobody is asked to adopt a practice. Everyone is invited to consider the teaching.

1.6 WHAT THE THREE TEACHERS CONTRIBUTE

Sri Ramakrishna gives direct experience: he worshipped Her, spoke with Her, and reported what he saw. Holy Mother gives the motherhood of God in a human life, lived in a village kitchen and a Calcutta house. Swami Vivekananda gives the philosophy and the honest struggle: he rejected Kali for six years before accepting Her, and he could explain to a Western audience exactly what the image means.

Our evening



ON THE SLIDE

The evening follows the old order of Vedantic learning: listening to the teaching, reflecting on it, and sitting quietly until it settles. Tonight reflection happens twice: in the questions marked on the slides during the talk, and in the question time at 7.15 pm.

New tonight: several slides carry a question in a green box. Some are for a minute of silence, some for the person beside you, some for the whole room. Four of them are marked with a star; if time is short we will use those. These slides are shared afterwards, so please do not photograph them.

2.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Śravaṇa / श्रवण	listening to the teaching
Manana / मनन	reflecting on it until doubts clear
Nididhyāsana / निदिध्यासन	sustained contemplation until it becomes one's own experience

2.2 HOW THE EVENING RUNS

Arrival and refreshments from 6.15 pm, a guided meditation at 6.30, the talk from 6.45, questions and discussion at 7.15, and we close by 8.00. Please bring your questions. Tonight there is also discussion during the talk: several slides carry a question for you to sit with or to talk over with the person next to you. These slides are shared afterwards, so there is no need to photograph them.

2.3 WHY WE BEGIN WITH A QUESTION AND NOT AN ANSWER

Vedanta is learned in three movements: listening, reflecting, and deep contemplation until the teaching becomes experience. Reflection has to start from something of our own. So before any teaching, we begin with one minute of silence and one honest question. Whatever answer comes, even an embarrassing one, is the real starting point.

2.4 WHY DISCUSSION, AND NOT ONLY A TALK

Information about the Divine Mother is easy to find and easy to forget. What stays is what we have said out loud in our own words, or recognised in our own life. The questions tonight are not a test. There are no correct answers, and nobody will be asked to report. The point is to make the teaching touch one real situation in each person's life before they go home.

2.5 A MONTHLY RHYTHM

The Hamilton class meets on the first Wednesday of each month. A teaching heard once fades. A monthly meeting gives a rhythm of hearing, practising for a few weeks, and returning with questions, and bringing one real experience from the month to the question time is the most useful way to use it.

2.6 REFLECT

In real trouble, or in real joy, whom do I call out to, and in what words? Do not answer aloud yet. Just notice the words that come.

Why Kali, why now



ON THE SLIDE

Kali Puja and Diwali fall on the same night this year, Sunday 8 November 2026, the new moon of Kartik. In much of India that night is Lakshmi Puja; in Bengal, and at Dakshineswar and Belur Math, it is Kali Puja. This class is four days before, so tonight's practices are for the days leading up to it.

There is a deliberate beauty in worshipping the dark Mother on the darkest night of the month, surrounded by rows of lamps. Darkness is not denied. It is Hers too, and the light is lit inside it. Swami Vivekananda, on such a night, said of the sky: "Do you see what a mysterious and solemn beauty there is in this darkness!"

3.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Amāvasyā / अमावस्या	the new moon night, when the moon is not seen at all
Kārtika / कार्तिक	the lunar month, roughly October to November
Dakṣiṇeśvar / दक्षिणेश्वर	the Kali temple on the Ganga, founded by Rani Rasmani, where Sri Ramakrishna was priest

3.2 KALI PUJA AND DIWALI

This year Diwali and Kali Puja fall on the same night, Sunday 8 November 2026, the new moon of Kartik. Across northern and western India that night is Lakshmi Puja, and lamps are lit for prosperity and for the return of Rama. In Bengal, and at Dakshineswar and Belur Math, the same night is Kali Puja. Our class falls four days before, so the practices offered tonight are meant for the days leading up to that night and for the night itself.

3.3 WHY A DARK GODDESS ON THE NIGHT OF LAMPS

There is a deliberate beauty in it. On the darkest night of the month, when there is no moon at all, the tradition lights rows of lamps and worships God as the dark Mother. The message is not that darkness is to be denied but that it is Her too, and that the light we need is lit inside

the darkness, not somewhere else. Swami Vivekananda, standing outside on such a night, said of the dark sky: "Do you see what a mysterious and solemn beauty there is in this darkness!"

3.4 A FESTIVAL IS A DOOR

Festivals are not only memories. They are set times when a whole community turns in one direction, and it becomes easier to begin something. If we have wanted to start japa, or an evening review, or simply to speak to God as Mother, the days before Diwali are a good time to start, and a community that starts together keeps going longer.

3.5 ONE NIGHT, MANY NAMES

The same new moon night of Kartik carries Lakshmi Puja in the north and west, Kali Puja in Bengal, and Diwali everywhere. The festivals are not rivals. Prosperity and the power of time are both aspects of one Mother, and in Bengali households many families keep both. Our Centre keeps the night as Kali Puja, in the Ramakrishna Order's tradition, and welcomes everyone who keeps it in any form.

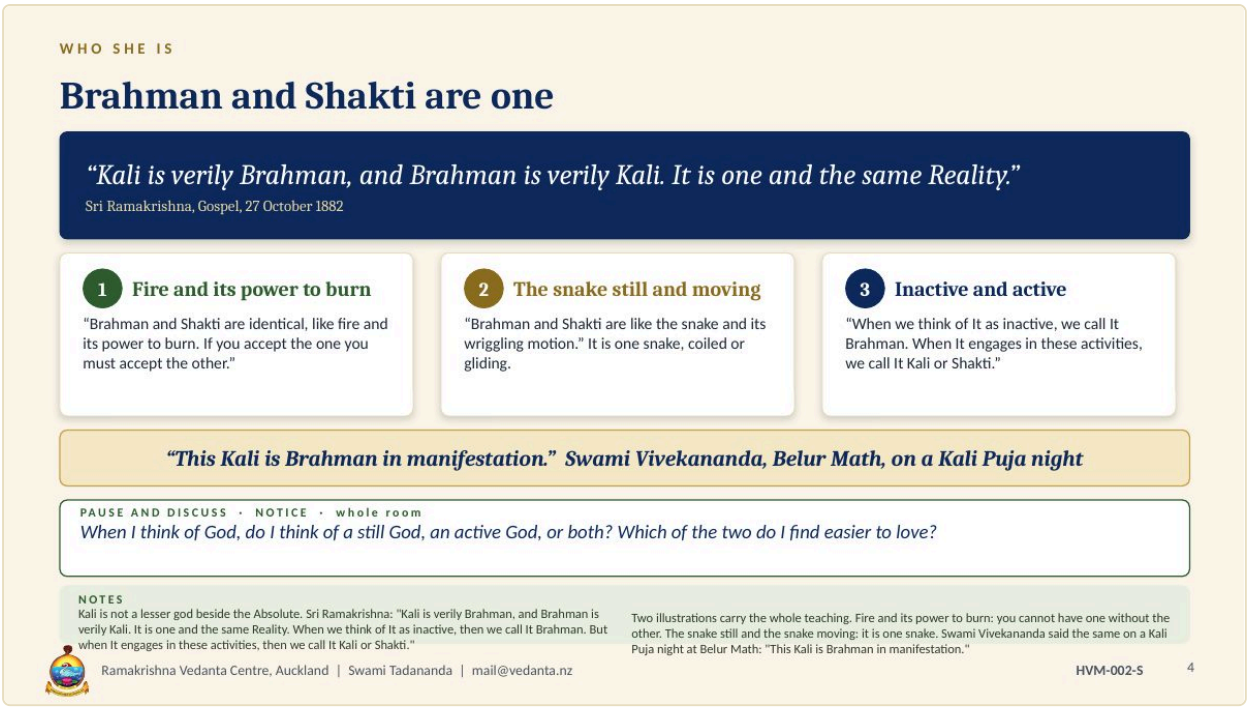
3.6 PHALAHARINI KALI PUJA, A DIFFERENT NIGHT

A note to prevent confusion. The night on which Sri Ramakrishna worshipped Holy Mother as the Divine Mother, in 1872, was the Phalaharini Kali Puja, which falls in the month of Jyaistha, around May or June, when the Divine Mother is worshipped as the consumer of the karmas of Her devotee. That is a separate occasion from the Kali Puja of Kartik which we are approaching now.

3.7 REFLECT

When did light come to me at a dark time, and through whom did it come?

Brahman and Shakti are one



ON THE SLIDE

Kali is not a lesser god beside the Absolute. Sri Ramakrishna: "Kali is verily Brahman, and Brahman is verily Kali. It is one and the same Reality. When we think of It as inactive, then we call It Brahman. But when It engages in these activities, then we call It Kali or Shakti."

Two illustrations carry the whole teaching. Fire and its power to burn: you cannot have one without the other. The snake still and the snake moving: it is one snake. Swami Vivekananda said the same on a Kali Puja night at Belur Math: "This Kali is Brahman in manifestation."

4.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Brahman / ब्रह्मन्	the one Reality, spoken of as it is in itself, beyond change
Śakti / शक्ति	the same Reality spoken of as power, creating, preserving and dissolving
Cit / चित्	consciousness

4.2 ONE REALITY, TWO WAYS OF SPEAKING

The first thing to be clear about is that Kali is not a lesser god beside the Absolute. Sri Ramakrishna put it plainly: "This Power is called Kali. Kali is verily Brahman, and Brahman is verily Kali. It is one and the same Reality. When we think of It as inactive, that is to say, not engaged in the acts of creation, preservation, and destruction, then we call It Brahman. But when It engages in these activities, then we call It Kali or Shakti."

4.3 FIRE AND ITS POWER TO BURN

His favourite illustration: "Brahman and Shakti are identical, like fire and its power to burn. When we talk of fire we automatically mean also its power to burn. Again, the fire's power to burn implies the fire itself. If you accept the one you must accept the other." You cannot have a fire that does not burn, and you cannot have burning without fire. In the same way you cannot have Reality without its power, nor the power without the Reality.

4.4 THE SNAKE AND ITS MOTION

A second illustration says the same from another side: "Brahman and Shakti are like the snake and its wriggling motion. Thinking of the snake, one must think of its wriggling motion, and thinking of its wriggling motion, one must think of the snake." And again: "Water is water whether it is still or in waves. The snake is a snake whether it is coiled up motionless or wriggles along." Swami Vivekananda used the same image on a Kali Puja night at Belur Math: "This Kali is Brahman in manifestation."

4.5 WHY THIS MATTERS FOR PRACTICE

If Kali were only a local deity, worship would be a small thing. Because She is Brahman in action, every prayer to Her is a prayer to the Absolute, and every honest dealing with the world is a dealing with Her. Nothing has to be left behind to reach Her, because there is nothing that is not Her.

4.6 WHY THE TWO WORDS ARE NOT TWO THINGS

Vedanta is often presented as teaching one formless Reality, with deities as a concession to weaker minds. Sri Ramakrishna's teaching is different and stricter: the power is not a concession, it is what the Reality is doing. Calling it Brahman and calling it Kali are two descriptions of one fact, as 'water' and 'wave' are. This is why he could move between the most rigorous non-dualism and the worship of an image in the same hour without contradiction.

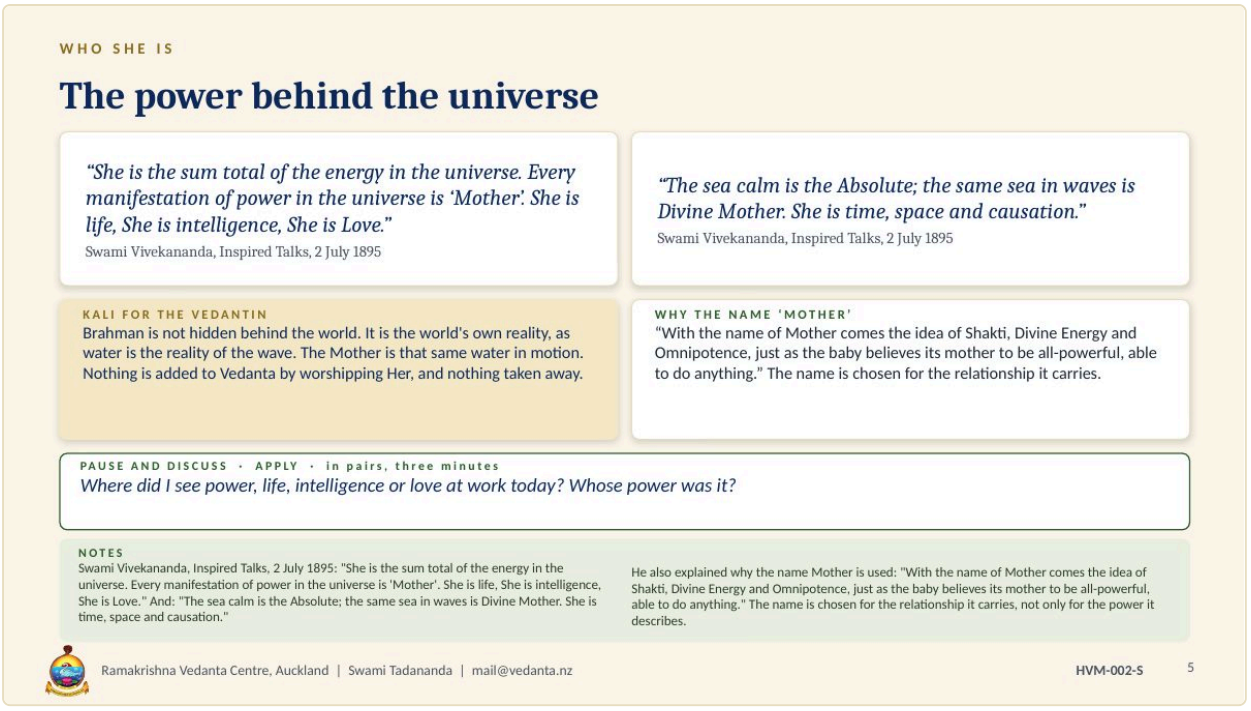
4.7 THE SNAKE AT REST AND IN MOTION

Swami Vivekananda, asked about the image on a Kali Puja night at Belur Math in 1901, answered: "This Kali is Brahman in manifestation. Haven't you heard Shri Ramakrishna's illustration of the snake moving and the snake at rest?" The illustration is deliberately homely. A snake coiled and a snake gliding differ in nothing but activity, and nobody imagines two snakes.

4.8 REFLECT

When I think of God, do I think of a still God, an active God, or both? Which of the two do I find easier to love?

The power behind the universe



ON THE SLIDE

Swami Vivekananda, Inspired Talks, 2 July 1895: "She is the sum total of the energy in the universe. Every manifestation of power in the universe is 'Mother'. She is life, She is intelligence, She is Love." And: "The sea calm is the Absolute; the same sea in waves is Divine Mother. She is time, space and causation."

He also explained why the name Mother is used: "With the name of Mother comes the idea of Shakti, Divine Energy and Omnipotence, just as the baby believes its mother to be all-powerful, able to do anything." The name is chosen for the relationship it carries, not only for the power it describes.

5.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Śākta / शाक्त	a worshipper of the Divine as Power, as Mother
Deśa-kāla-nimitta / देशकालनिमित्त	space, time and causation, the three conditions of the manifest world

5.2 SWAMI VIVEKANANDA ON THE DIVINE MOTHER

Speaking to a small group at Thousand Island Park in 1895, he said: "Shaktas worship the Universal Energy as Mother, the sweetest name they know; for the mother is the highest ideal of womanhood in India." And then: "With the name of Mother comes the idea of Shakti, Divine Energy and Omnipotence, just as the baby believes its mother to be all-powerful, able to do anything."

5.3 SHE IS THE SUM TOTAL OF ENERGY

His clearest statement is this: "She is the sum total of the energy in the universe. Every manifestation of power in the universe is 'Mother'. She is life, She is intelligence, She is Love." This is not poetry decorating a doctrine. It is the doctrine. Whatever acts, moves, grows, thinks or loves does so by Her.

5.4 THE CALM SEA AND THE WAVES

"The sea calm is the Absolute; the same sea in waves is Divine Mother. She is time, space and causation." One sea, two descriptions. When we speak of what is beyond change, we say Brahman. When we speak of the same thing as this moving, timed, located, caused world, we say Mother. That is why he could also write: "I am the child of the Divine Mother, the source of all power and strength."

5.5 WHY A GODDESS IN A PHILOSOPHY OF THE ONE

People trained to think of Vedanta as the philosophy of the one formless Reality sometimes feel that a goddess with a sword belongs to a different religion. Sri Ramakrishna's answer is the fire and its power to burn: the two are not two. The formless is what She is; the form is how She meets us. He said of Her: "My Divine Mother is not only formless, She has forms as well. One can see Her forms. One can behold Her incomparable beauty through feeling and love."

5.6 KALI FOR THE VEDANTIN

For those who come to this from philosophy rather than devotion, the bridge is the sea and its waves. Brahman is not a thing hidden behind the world; it is the world's own reality, as water is the reality of the wave. The Mother is that same water in motion. Nothing is being added to Vedanta by worshipping Her, and nothing is being taken away. The difference is only whether we approach the one Reality as a truth to be known or as a person to be loved, and Sri Ramakrishna's life shows that one person may do both.

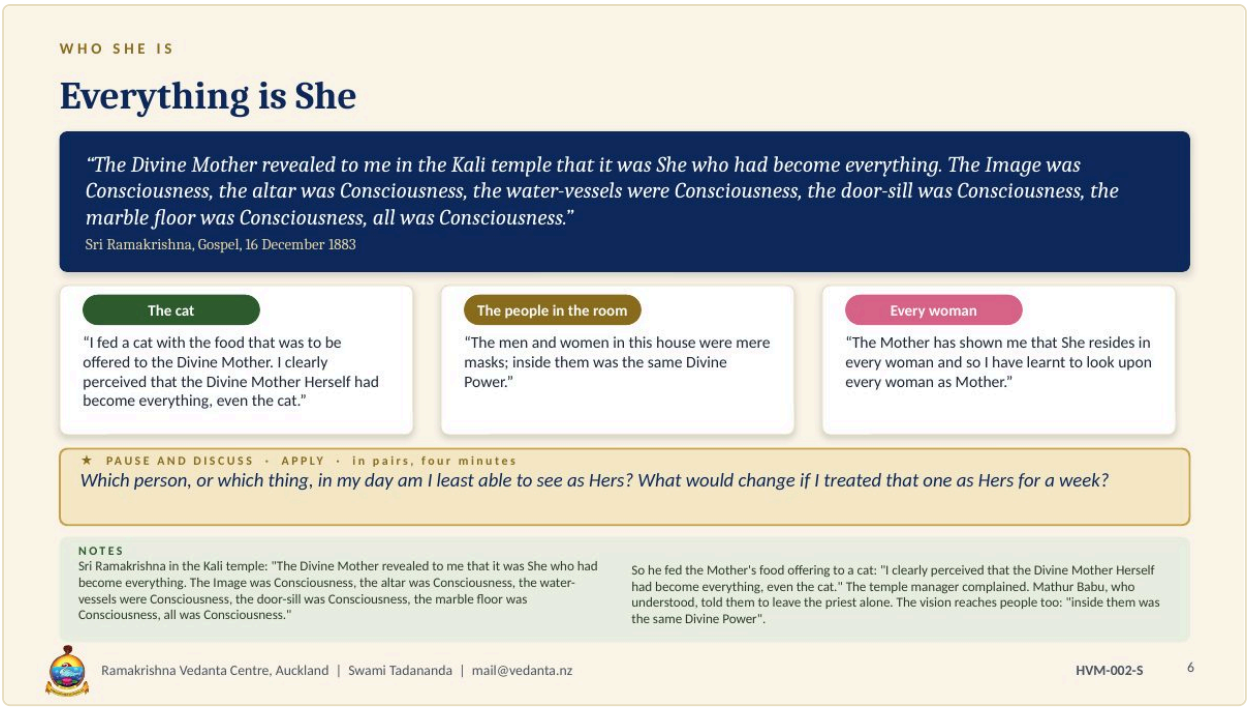
5.7 A HINDU INVOCATION HE QUOTED

In the Inspired Talks he quotes an invocation: "That Mother whose voice is in the thunder, come Thou in me! Kali, Thou time eternal, Thou force irresistible, Shakti, Power!" It is worth noting the request. Not 'come to me', but 'come in me'. The power is not asked to visit from outside; it is asked to act as the one praying.

5.8 REFLECT

Where did I see power, life, intelligence or love at work today? Whose power was it?

Everything is She



ON THE SLIDE

Sri Ramakrishna in the Kali temple: "The Divine Mother revealed to me that it was She who had become everything. The Image was Consciousness, the altar was Consciousness, the water-vessels were Consciousness, the door-sill was Consciousness, the marble floor was Consciousness, all was Consciousness."

So he fed the Mother's food offering to a cat: "I clearly perceived that the Divine Mother Herself had become everything, even the cat." The temple manager complained. Mathur Babu, who understood, told them to leave the priest alone. The vision reaches people too: "inside them was the same Divine Power".

6.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Cinmaya / चिन्मय	made of consciousness, full of Consciousness
Prasāda / प्रसाद	food or anything offered to the Divine and received back as grace

6.2 THE VISION IN THE KALI TEMPLE

Sri Ramakrishna described what he saw in the temple at Dakshineswar: "The Divine Mother revealed to me in the Kali temple that it was She who had become everything. She showed me that everything was full of Consciousness. The Image was Consciousness, the altar was Consciousness, the water-vessels were Consciousness, the door-sill was Consciousness, the marble floor was Consciousness, all was Consciousness." The Bengali word he used is chinmaya, made of Consciousness.

6.3 THE CAT AND THE OFFERING

What he did next is the part people remember. "That was why I fed a cat with the food that was to be offered to the Divine Mother. I clearly perceived that the Divine Mother Herself had become everything, even the cat." The temple manager complained to Mathur Babu that the

priest was giving the Mother's offering to a cat. Mathur, who understood the state his priest was in, wrote back and told them to leave him alone.

6.4 IN EVERY THOUGHT, WORD AND DEED

He went further than objects. "No sooner did this thought arise in my mind than the Divine Mother revealed to me in a flash that it is She Herself who has become man." Of the people in a room he said: "The Divine Mother revealed to me that the men and women in this house were mere masks; inside them was the same Divine Power." Seeing someone as a mask with Her behind it changes how we speak to them.

6.5 WHAT THIS ASKS OF US

We cannot manufacture that vision. What we can do is act as if it were true in one small matter at a time: the person who serves us, the animal in the house, the room we are tidying. Practice begins where belief has not yet reached.

6.6 THIS IS THE CENTRE OF THE EVENING

If only one thing is remembered tonight, it should be this: She has become everything, including the people and objects we find ordinary or irritating. Every practice offered later, the offering line before work, seeing Her in a difficult person, making the house ready for Her, is an attempt to live for one hour as though this vision were true. Practice begins exactly where belief has not yet reached.

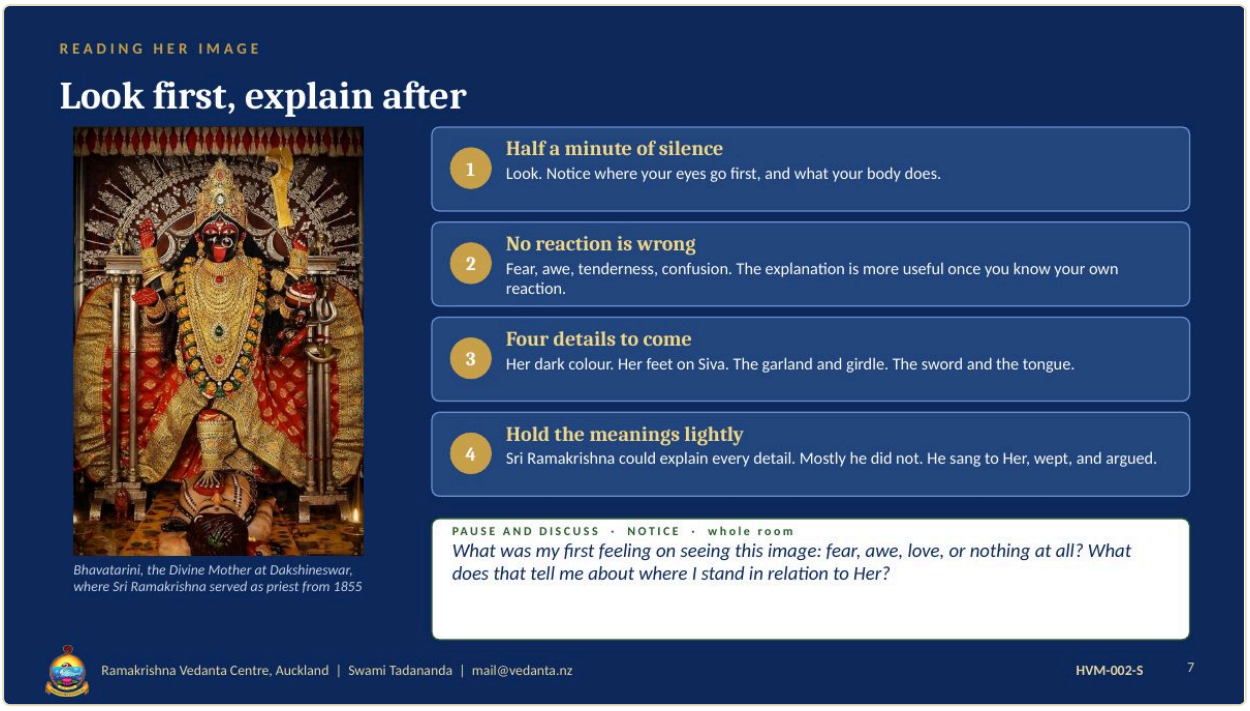
6.7 SEEING HER IN WOMEN AND IN ALL BEINGS

Sri Ramakrishna's realisation changed his behaviour completely. He told his wife, "the Mother has shown me that She resides in every woman and so I have learnt to look upon every woman as Mother." He saluted two prostitutes on a verandah, saying they appeared to him as embodiments of the Divine Mother. Swami Vivekananda drew the social conclusion: where Shakti is held in dishonour, a society weakens. The vision is not private mysticism; it has consequences for how a household and a community behave.

6.8 REFLECT

Which person, or which thing, in my day am I least able to see as Hers? What would change if I treated that one as Hers for a week?

Look first, explain after



ON THE SLIDE

Before any explanation, look at the photograph for half a minute in silence. Notice where your eyes go first, and what your body does. Fear, awe, tenderness and confusion are all common, and none of them is wrong. The explanation is more useful once you know your own reaction.

This is Bhavatarini at Dakshineswar, the same image Sri Ramakrishna dressed, fed, sang to and argued with every day for years. Each symbol carries a teaching, and we will take four of them in turn: the dark colour, the feet on Siva, the garland and girdle, and the sword and tongue.

7.1 LOOK FIRST, EXPLAIN AFTER

We will spend the next few slides reading the image of the Mother. Before any explanation, look at the photograph in silence for half a minute. Notice what your eyes go to first and what your body does. Fear, awe, tenderness and confusion are all common, and none is wrong. The explanation is more useful once you know your own reaction.

7.2 WHAT THE IMAGE IS

This is Bhavatarini, "She who takes one across the ocean of worldly existence", in the temple at Dakshineswar founded by Rani Rasmani, where Sri Ramakrishna served as priest. The temple garden also holds twelve Siva temples and a Radhakanta temple, and the Ganga runs past it. The symbols on this image are not decoration. Each one carries a teaching, and the tradition is quite precise about what each means.

7.3 A WARNING ABOUT SYMBOLS

Symbols can be over-explained until the figure becomes a diagram. Sri Ramakrishna, who could explain each detail, mostly did not. He sang to Her, wept, laughed, scolded and argued. Hold the meanings lightly, as doors into a relationship, not as a code to be solved.

7.4 HOLD THE MEANINGS LIGHTLY

Symbols can be explained until the figure becomes a diagram and the Mother disappears. Sri Ramakrishna, who could explain every detail, mostly did not. He wept before Her, laughed, demanded and sang. The explanations are doors into a relationship, not a code to be cracked. If an explanation does not help you, leave it; if a detail moves you without explanation, that is better than understanding it.

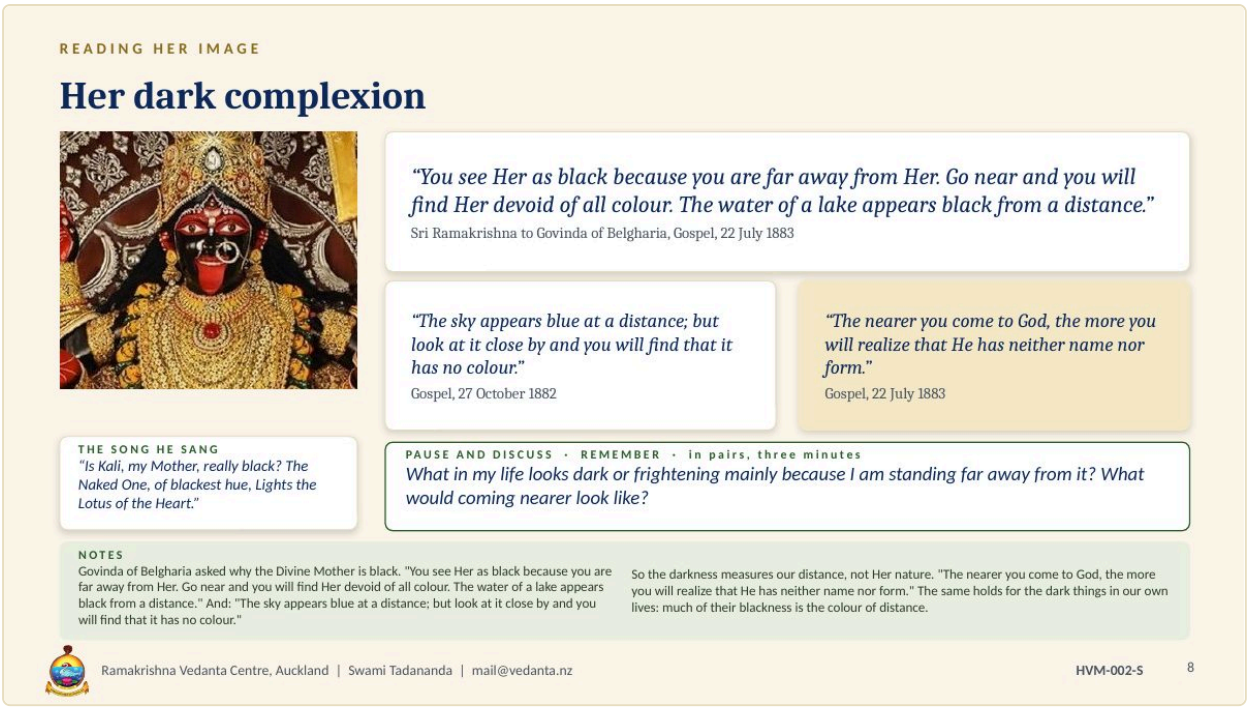
7.5 WHY LOOK AT ALL

Vedanta does not require images, and many people worship without any. But most of us think in pictures whether we choose to or not. A tradition that gives a considered image at least ensures that the picture in the mind carries a teaching, instead of being assembled from whatever we happened to see.

7.6 REFLECT

What was my first feeling on seeing this image: fear, awe, love, or nothing at all? What does that tell me about where I stand in relation to Her?

Her dark complexion



ON THE SLIDE

Govinda of Belgharia asked why the Divine Mother is black. "You see Her as black because you are far away from Her. Go near and you will find Her devoid of all colour. The water of a lake appears black from a distance." And: "The sky appears blue at a distance; but look at it close by and you will find that it has no colour."

So the darkness measures our distance, not Her nature. "The nearer you come to God, the more you will realize that He has neither name nor form." The same holds for the dark things in our own lives: much of their blackness is the colour of distance.

8.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Śyāmā / श्यामा	the dark one; a name of Kali, used for the gentler household form
Kāla / काल	black, and also time; the Ramprasad song plays on both meanings

8.2 WHY IS SHE DARK?

A devotee named Govinda asked Sri Ramakrishna exactly this. The answer: "You see Her as black because you are far away from Her. Go near and you will find Her devoid of all colour. The water of a lake appears black from a distance." And to the Brahmo leader Keshab Sen he said: "Is Kali, my Divine Mother, of a black complexion? She appears black because She is viewed from a distance; but when intimately known She is no longer so. The sky appears blue at a distance; but look at it close by and you will find that it has no colour."

8.3 DISTANCE, NOT DARKNESS

The teaching is about us, not about Her. Her apparent darkness is a measure of our distance. The nearer we come, the less colour there is, until, as he said, "The nearer you come to God, the more you will realize that He has neither name nor form." Those who have come near do not find a dark goddess. They find what cannot be described at all.

8.4 THE SONG HE SANG

He followed that answer with a song: "Is Kali, my Mother, really black? The Naked One, of blackest hue, Lights the Lotus of the Heart." And from a song of Ramprasad: "Beneath Her feet lies Maha-Kala. Why should Her hue be kala, black? Many the forms of black, but She appears astoundingly black." Holy Mother remembered the Master's delight when she sent a garland to the temple: "Ah! These flowers are so nicely set off against the dark complexion of the Divine Mother!"

8.5 THE DARKNESS WE MEET IN LIFE

The same principle applies to our circumstances. Grief, illness and failure look black from outside. People who have passed through them and stayed close to Her often say afterwards that the darkness had no colour of its own. We are not asked to pretend that dark things are bright. We are told that distance is part of what makes them look as they do.

8.6 THE SONGS HE SANG ON THIS

He followed his answer to Keshab Sen with a song: "Is Kali, my Mother, really black? The Naked One, of blackest hue, Lights the Lotus of the Heart." Another, from Ramprasad: "Beneath Her feet lies Maha-Kala. Why should Her hue be kala, black? Many the forms of black, but She appears astoundingly black." The songs do not settle the question; they hold it open and make it beautiful, which is a different kind of answer.

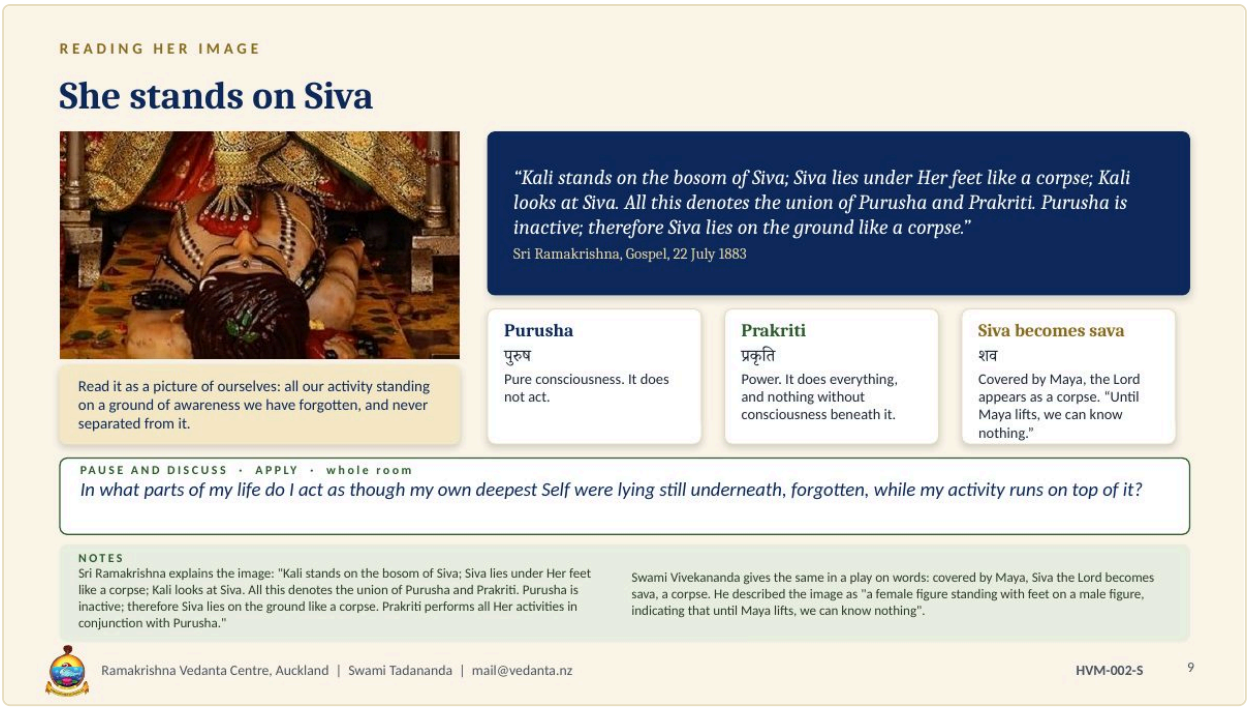
8.7 A MEMORY OF HOLY MOTHER

She remembered making a garland at Dakshineswar and sending it to the temple. "He at once fell into an ecstatic mood to see the beauty of Kali so much enhanced by the flowers. Again and again he said, 'Ah! These flowers are so nicely set off against the dark complexion of the Divine Mother!'" The theology of the dark colour sits beside a husband's delight at how flowers looked against it.

8.8 REFLECT

What in my life looks dark or frightening mainly because I am standing far away from it? What would coming nearer look like?

She stands on Siva



ON THE SLIDE

Sri Ramakrishna explains the image: "Kali stands on the bosom of Siva; Siva lies under Her feet like a corpse; Kali looks at Siva. All this denotes the union of Purusha and Prakriti. Purusha is inactive; therefore Siva lies on the ground like a corpse. Prakriti performs all Her activities in conjunction with Purusha."

Swami Vivekananda gives the same in a play on words: covered by Maya, Siva the Lord becomes sava, a corpse. He described the image as "a female figure standing with feet on a male figure, indicating that until Maya lifts, we can know nothing".

9.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Puruṣa / पुरुष	pure consciousness, which does not act
Prakṛti / प्रकृति	nature or power, which acts, and never apart from consciousness
Śava / शव	a corpse; the word play with Śiva

9.2 THE DETAIL PEOPLE ASK ABOUT MOST

A woman standing on the chest of a man who lies like a corpse is startling, and it is the first thing visitors want explained. Sri Ramakrishna's explanation is short and complete: "Take the image of Siva and Kali. Kali stands on the bosom of Siva; Siva lies under Her feet like a corpse; Kali looks at Siva. All this denotes the union of Purusha and Prakriti."

9.3 PURUSHA AND PRAKRITI

He continues: "Purusha is inactive; therefore Siva lies on the ground like a corpse. Prakriti performs all Her activities in conjunction with Purusha. Thus She creates, preserves, and destroys." Purusha is pure consciousness, which does not act. Prakriti is nature or power, which does everything, and does nothing without consciousness beneath it. The image is a diagram of this: all activity standing on an unmoving ground, and never separated from it.

9.4 SIVA AND SAVA

Swami Vivekananda gave the same teaching with a play on words. Siva, the Lord, becomes sava, a corpse, when covered by Maya: "Brahman is neuter, unknown and unknowable, but to be objectified He covers Himself with a veil of Maya, becomes the Mother of the Universe and so brings forth the creation. The prostrate figure has become Shava by being covered by Maya." He also described the image simply as "a female figure standing with feet on a male figure, indicating that until Maya lifts, we can know nothing."

9.5 TWO WAYS TO THE SAME GOAL

He drew the practical conclusion in one sentence: "The Jnani says, 'I will uncover God by force' (Advaitism); but the dualist says, 'I will uncover God by praying to Mother, begging Her to open the door to which She alone has the key.'" Both are respected in our tradition. The second is open to everyone, in every condition, at any hour.

9.6 A DIAGRAM OF OUR OWN CONDITION

Read the image as a picture of ourselves. Underneath everything we do lies awareness, which does nothing and knows everything. On top of it runs all our activity. We spend our days identified with the activity and forget the ground it stands on. The image does not ask us to stop acting; it asks us to remember what the acting stands on, and it shows the two as inseparable, Her feet always touching Him.

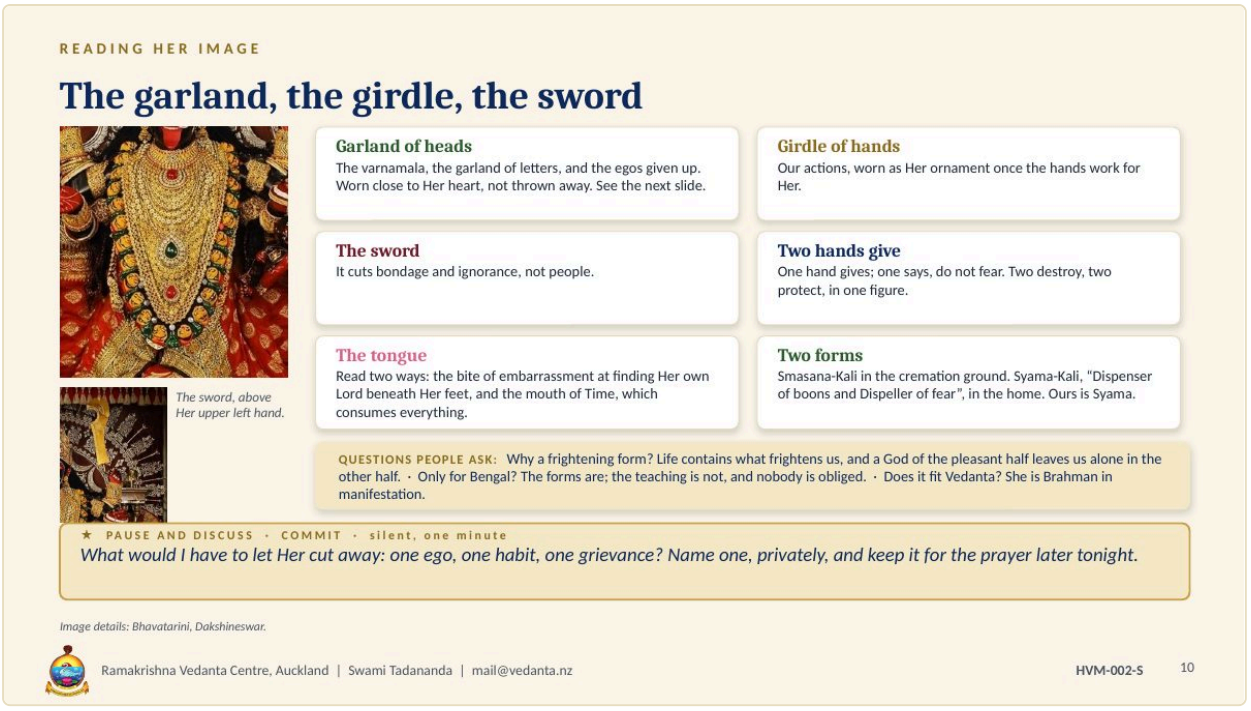
9.7 TWO ROADS, BOTH OURS

Swami Vivekananda's summary is worth memorising: "The Jnani says, 'I will uncover God by force' (Advaitism); but the dualist says, 'I will uncover God by praying to Mother, begging Her to open the door to which She alone has the key.'" The Ramakrishna tradition holds both roads open and insists that the second is not inferior. It is the one available to a person in the middle of a working life, with no leisure for metaphysics.

9.8 REFLECT

In what parts of my life do I act as though my own deepest Self were lying still underneath, forgotten, while my activity runs on top of it?

The garland, the girdle, the sword



ON THE SLIDE

Two forms, two moods. "Smasana-Kali is the embodiment of the power of destruction. From Her neck hangs a garland of human heads, and around Her waist is a girdle made of human hands." And the one in our picture: "Syama-Kali has a somewhat tender aspect and is worshipped in the Hindu households. She is the Dispenser of boons and the Dispeller of fear."

The tradition reads the garland of heads as egos given up and worn at Her heart, the girdle of hands as our actions made into Her ornament, and the sword as the cutter of ignorance, not of people. Two hands destroy; two hands give and say, do not fear.

10.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Śmaśāna / श्मशान	the cremation ground, where the fierce form is worshipped
Abhaya / अभय	fearlessness; the gesture of the raised hand that says, do not fear
Vara / वर	boon; the gesture of the lowered open hand that gives

10.2 TWO FORMS, TWO MOODS

Keshab Sen once asked in how many ways Kali sports in this world, and Sri Ramakrishna distinguished Her forms. Of the fierce one: "Smasana-Kali is the embodiment of the power of destruction. She resides in the cremation ground, surrounded by corpses, jackals, and terrible female spirits. From Her mouth flows a stream of blood, from Her neck hangs a garland of human heads, and around Her waist is a girdle made of human hands." Of the one worshipped in homes, and the one in our photograph: "Syama-Kali has a somewhat tender aspect and is worshipped in the Hindu households. She is the Dispenser of boons and the Dispeller of fear."

10.3 THE GARLAND AND THE GIRDLE

The garland of heads is read in two ways that belong together. It is the varnamala, the garland of letters, the aksharas of the alphabet worn at Her heart; and it is the ego, severed,

one head for each of us who has given it up. The next slide takes the first reading further. The girdle of hands is read as karma, the hands of action, which She wears as an ornament once they work for Her. A song the Master sang asks Her, half in protest: "Where didst Thou find Thy garland of heads before the universe was made? Thou art the Mover of all that move, and we are but Thy helpless toys."

10.4 THE SWORD, THE HANDS, THE TONGUE

The sword cuts, and what it cuts is bondage and ignorance, not people. The lower right hand gives, and the upper right hand says do not fear, so two hands destroy and two hands protect, in one figure. The tongue is commonly explained in two ways: as the bite of embarrassment when She finds Her own Lord under Her feet, and as the mouth of Time that consumes everything. These readings are the tradition's, not quotations from our books, and should be given as such.

10.5 ANOTHER SONG, AND A PRAYER FOR THE SWEET FORM

Many devotees quietly prefer the gentle face, and the tradition makes room for that too. The Master sang: "Where hast Thou hidden that lovely form, O terrible Syama? Dance that way once for me, O Mother! Throw down Thy sword and take the flute; Cast off Thy garland of heads, and wear Thy wild-flower garland."

10.6 WHAT TO SAY IF SOMEONE IS TROUBLED BY THE FORM

Why worship a frightening form? Because life contains what frightens us, and a God who covers only the pleasant half leaves us alone in the other half. Is this only for Bengal? The forms are Bengali; the teaching is not. Swami Vivekananda wrote to Mary Hale: "Kali worship is my special fad; you never heard me preach it or read of my preaching it in India." Nobody is obliged to take up this worship. Does it fit Vedanta? See slide 4: She is Brahman in manifestation.

10.7 THE TONGUE

Two explanations are given for the tongue. The first is the bite of embarrassment: in the story, She stops in the middle of Her dance on finding Her own Lord beneath Her feet, and bites Her tongue as any woman of that culture would on realising what she had done. The second is that it is the mouth of Time, which consumes everything. Both are the tradition's readings, and both are usually given together, because the image holds the terrible and the tender in one face.

10.8 THE PRAYER FOR THE SWEETER FORM

The tradition makes room for those who cannot take the fierce form. The Master himself sang: "Where hast Thou hidden that lovely form, O terrible Syama? Dance that way once for me, O Mother! Throw down Thy sword and take the flute; Cast off Thy garland of heads, and wear Thy wild-flower garland." Swami Vivekananda's poem 'And Let Shyama Dance There' answers the same impulse from the other side: those who garland Her with skulls then shrink back and call Her all-merciful, and he will not let the sword be exchanged for a lute.

10.9 QUESTIONS PEOPLE ASK

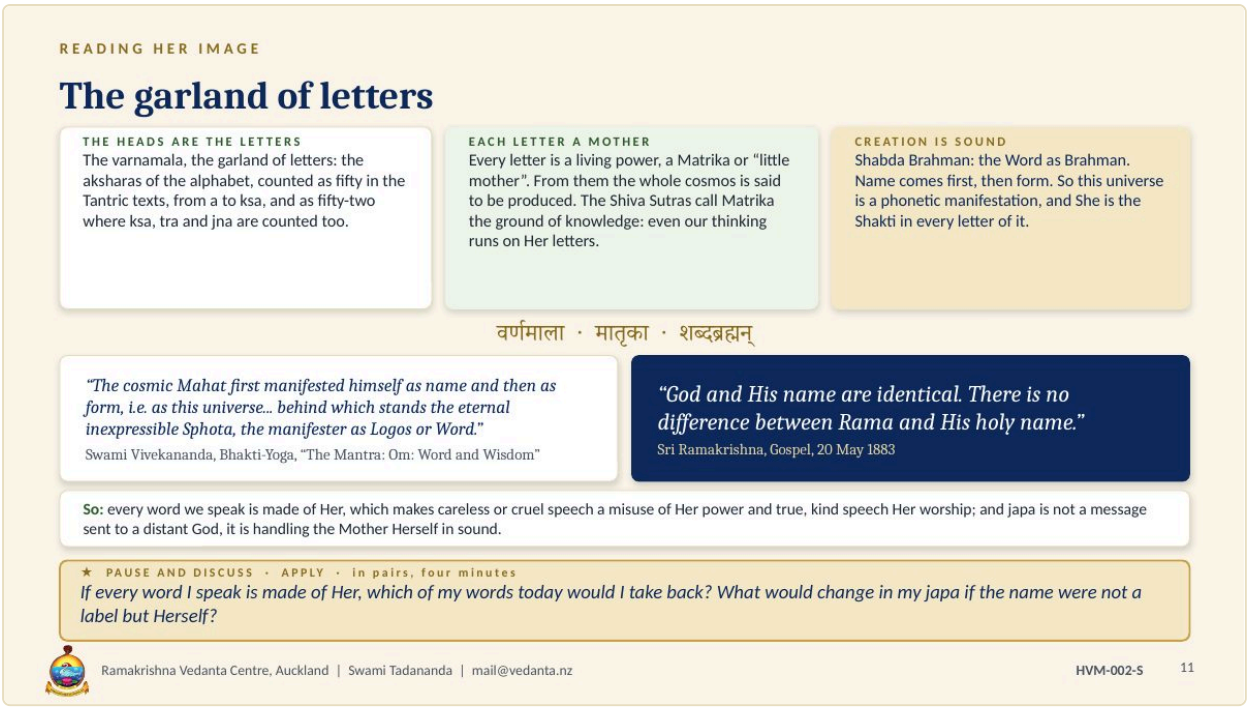
Why worship a frightening form? Because life contains what frightens us, and a God responsible only for pleasant things leaves us alone in the other half. Is this only for Bengal? The forms are Bengali; the teaching is not, and nobody is obliged to take up the worship. Does

it fit Vedanta? She is Brahman in manifestation, as slide 4 showed. Is it morbid? Swami Vivekananda's answer was that it is the opposite: facing what we fear is what ends the fear.

10.10 REFLECT

What would I have to let Her cut away, one ego, one habit, one grievance, to come closer to Her? Name one, privately, and keep it for later tonight.

The garland of letters



ON THE SLIDE

The garland is read as the varnamala, the garland of letters: the aksharas of the alphabet, fifty in the Tantric reckoning and fifty-two where ksa, tra and jna are counted too. Each letter is a living power, a Matrika or little mother, and the whole cosmos is said to be produced from them. The Shiva Sutras call Matrika the ground of knowledge.

Behind the letters is Shabda Brahman, the Word as Brahman: creation is sound, name first and then form. Swami Vivekananda: "the cosmic Mahat first manifested himself as name and then as form", behind which stands "the eternal inexpressible Sphota", called "the Nada-Brahma, the Sound-Brahman". So She is the Shakti in every letter, word, thought and deed.

11.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Varṇamālā / वर्णमाला	the garland of letters; the Sanskrit alphabet
Mātṛkā / मातृका	mother; the living sound-power of each letter, the “little mothers”
Śabda Brahman / शब्दब्रह्मन्	the Word as Brahman; Reality known as Sound
Sphoṭa / स्फोट	the eternal Word behind all words, which Swami Vivekananda calls Nāda-Brahma
Akṣara / अक्षर	a letter or syllable; also “imperishable”

11.2 THE HEADS ARE THE LETTERS

The garland She wears is read in our tradition as the varnamala, the garland of letters: the aksharas of the Sanskrit alphabet, counted as fifty in the Tantric texts, from a to ksa, and as fifty-two where ksa, tra and jna are counted as well. Pravrajika Brahmaprana of our own Order puts it plainly: "The garland of fifty skulls represents the fifty letters of the Sanskrit alphabet, which also means speech." The scholar David Kinsley records the same reading of the fifty or fifty-two heads, and says that on this reading the garland identifies Kali as Shabda Brahman, the Ultimate Reality known as Sound.

11.3 MATRIKA, THE LITTLE MOTHERS

Each letter is not a mark on a page but a living power, and the tradition calls these powers the Matrikas, the little mothers. Matrika means mother, and the name is exact: sound is what gives birth. Every word any of us has ever spoken is made of them, and so is every name of God. They are grouped in eight classes, each presided over by a goddess, and together they are called the mother of the universe because the whole cosmos is produced from them. The Shiva Sutras call Matrika the ground of knowledge, which is to say that even our thinking runs on Her letters.

11.4 SHABDA BRAHMAN, CREATION AS SOUND

Behind the letters stands the teaching of Shabda Brahman, the Word as Brahman: that this creation is a phonetic manifestation, name first and then form. Swami Vivekananda gives it in our own books, in Bhakti-Yoga: "In the universe, Brahma or Hiranyagarbha or the cosmic Mahat first manifested himself as name and then as form, i.e. as this universe." Behind all this, he says, "stands the eternal inexpressible Sphota, the manifester as Logos or Word", and "this Sphota is called the Nada-Brahma, the Sound-Brahman". In Karma-Yoga he says it in plainer words still: "In every religion the power of the word is recognised, so much so that in some of them creation itself is said to have come out of the word. The external aspect of the thought of God is the Word."

11.5 SO SHE IS THE SHAKTI IN EVERY WORD

Put the two together and the garland stops being grim. If creation is sound, and every letter is a Matrika, then She is the power in every letter, every word, every thought and every deed. Nothing we say is outside Her. Sri Ramakrishna draws the practical conclusion in one line: "God and His name are identical; that is the reason Radha said that. There is no difference between Rama and His holy name." This is why japa works. The name is not a label pointing at a distant God. The name is the God, in sound.

11.6 WHAT IT ASKS OF US

Two things. First, reverence for speech: if every word is made of Her, then careless, cruel or false speech is a misuse of Her power, and kind and true speech is Her worship. Second, confidence in japa: the one who repeats Her name is handling the Mother Herself, not a reminder of Her. The Master sang, "Taking the name of Kali, dive deep down, O mind, Into the heart’s fathomless depths, Where many a precious gem lies hid."

11.7 WHY THIS TURNS THE GARLAND AROUND

Read as trophies of battle, the garland is grim. Read as the varnamala it is the opposite: She wears the whole of language at Her heart, which is to say the whole of creation, since creation is said to come as name before it comes as form. The reading of the heads as severed egos and the reading of them as letters do not conflict. What is given up in the first is exactly what the second says we are made of: the name we answer to, and the words we defend.

11.8 THE NUMBER, AND HOW TO STATE IT

The usual Tantric count is fifty, from a to kṣa, and the Matrikas are grouped in eight classes, each with a presiding goddess, for example Brāhmī for the ka group. Fifty-one is counted where kṣa is added separately, and fifty-two where kṣa, tra and jña are all counted, which is the reckoning most people meet in school. David Kinsley records the heads as “fifty or fifty-

two”. When speaking publicly it is safest to say “the letters of the alphabet, counted as fifty or fifty-two”, and not to insist on one number.

11.9 WHERE THIS COMES FROM, AND WHERE IT DOES NOT

The identification of the heads with the letters, the Matrikas and Shabda Brahman belongs to the Tantric and Shaiva literature: the Shiva Sutras, Abhinavagupta’s Tantraloka, and in English Sir John Woodroffe’s The Garland of Letters. Within our own tradition the teaching is given in Swami Vivekananda’s Bhakti-Yoga, in the sections “The Mantra: Om: Word and Wisdom” and “Bija Mantras”, and in Karma-Yoga, in “We help ourselves, not the world”, on the power of the word; and the whole of it is contained in Sri Ramakrishna’s sentence that God and His name are identical.

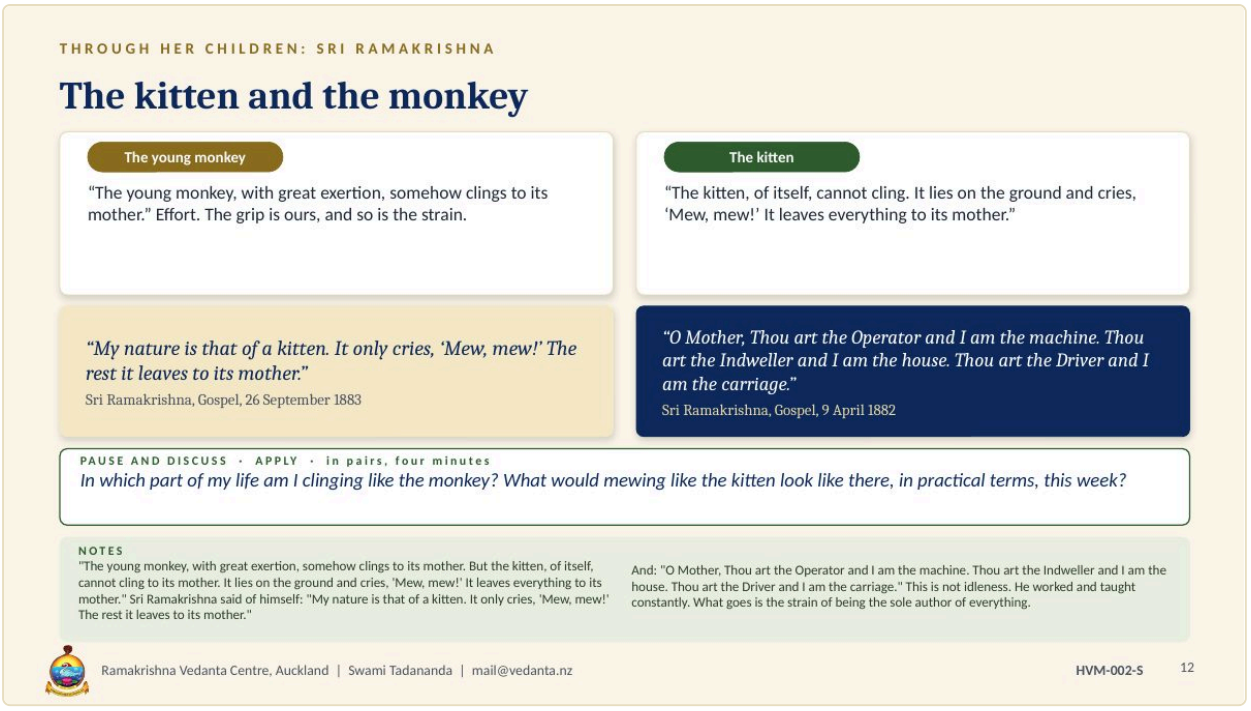
11.10 THE PRACTICAL EDGE: SPEECH AND JAPA

If every word is made of Her, speech is not a neutral tool. Gossip, contempt and falsehood are a misuse of the Mother’s own power; truthful, kind and few words are Her worship. And japa is not a reminder sent to a distant God, it is handling the Mother Herself in the form of sound. This is why both Sri Ramakrishna and Holy Mother return again and again to the name, and why Holy Mother tells us to keep repeating it whether the mind is steady or not.

11.11 REFLECT

If every word I speak is made of Her, which of my words today would I take back? And what would change in my japa if I believed the name were not a label but Herself?

The kitten and the monkey



ON THE SLIDE

"The young monkey, with great exertion, somehow clings to its mother. But the kitten, of itself, cannot cling to its mother. It lies on the ground and cries, 'Mew, mew!' It leaves everything to its mother." Sri Ramakrishna said of himself: "My nature is that of a kitten. It only cries, 'Mew, mew!' The rest it leaves to its mother."

And: "O Mother, Thou art the Operator and I am the machine. Thou art the Indweller and I am the house. Thou art the Driver and I am the carriage." This is not idleness. He worked and taught constantly. What goes is the strain of being the sole author of everything.

12.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Markaṭa-kiśora-nyāya / मर्कटकिशोरन्याय	the way of the young monkey: the devotee holds on by effort
Mārjāra-kiśora-nyāya / मार्जारकिशोरन्याय	the way of the kitten: the devotee is carried

12.2 TWO WAYS A CHILD HOLDS ON

Sri Ramakrishna: "The nature of the one kind is like that of the young monkey, and the nature of the other kind is like that of the kitten. The young monkey, with great exertion, somehow clings to its mother. But the kitten, of itself, cannot cling to its mother. It lies on the ground and cries, 'Mew, mew!' It leaves everything to its mother." The monkey holds on; the kitten is carried. Both reach the mother. One is exhausted on arrival.

12.3 HIS OWN NATURE

He said of himself: "My nature is that of a kitten. It only cries, 'Mew, mew!' The rest it leaves to its mother." And again: "I only call on Him as Mother. Let Mother do whatever She likes. I shall know Her if it is Her will; but I shall be happy to remain ignorant if She wills otherwise." That last sentence is worth sitting with. It is contentment without a condition attached.

12.4 THE OPERATOR AND THE MACHINE

"O Mother, Thou art the Operator and I am the machine. Thou art the Indweller and I am the house. Thou art the Driver and I am the carriage." And in another conversation: "I am the machine and Thou art the Operator; I am the chariot and Thou art the Driver. I move as Thou movest me; I do as Thou makest me do." This is not fatalism. He worked, served and taught constantly. It is the removal of the strain of being the sole author of everything.

12.5 WHERE THE CLINGING SHOWS

Most of us are monkeys in some areas and kittens in others. Watch where effort turns into gripping: a result that must come, a person who must change, an outcome that must be secured. That is where the hands are tight. Mewing is not giving up the work. It is doing the work while letting Her carry the result.

12.6 BOTH WAYS ARE HONOURED

The two images are not a ranking of devotees into better and worse. Temperaments differ, and the same person is a monkey in some areas of life and a kitten in others. The useful question is not which type am I, but where in my life has effort turned into gripping. That is where the hands are tight, and that is where the teaching applies.

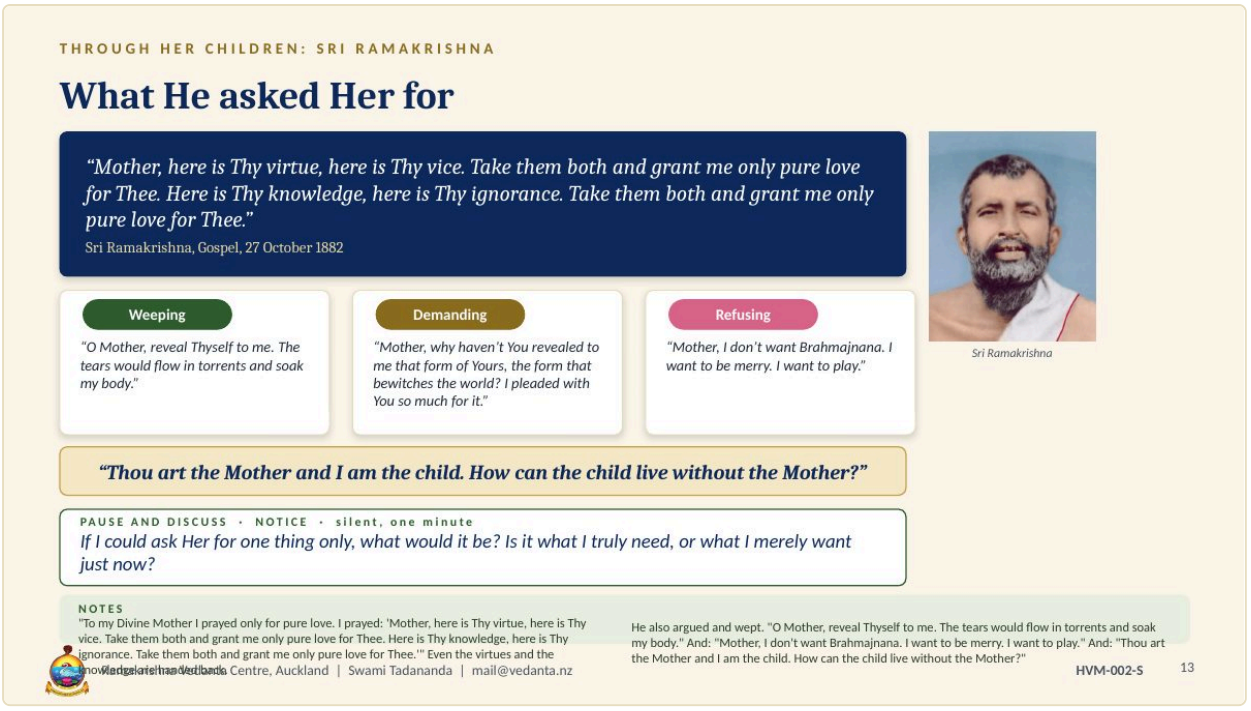
12.7 CONTENTMENT WITHOUT A CONDITION

One sentence of his deserves a long pause: "I shall know Her if it is Her will; but I shall be happy to remain ignorant if She wills otherwise." Most of our contentment has a condition attached, usually unspoken. This has none, and it is the mark of the kitten: not indifference to the goal, but trust in who is carrying us to it.

12.8 REFLECT

In which part of my life am I clinging like the monkey? What would mewing like the kitten look like there, in practical terms, this week?

What He asked Her for



ON THE SLIDE

"To my Divine Mother I prayed only for pure love. I prayed: 'Mother, here is Thy virtue, here is Thy vice. Take them both and grant me only pure love for Thee. Here is Thy knowledge, here is Thy ignorance. Take them both and grant me only pure love for Thee.'" Even the virtues and the knowledge are handed back.

He also argued and wept. "O Mother, reveal Thyself to me. The tears would flow in torrents and soak my body." And: "Mother, I don't want Brahmajnana. I want to be merry. I want to play." And: "Thou art the Mother and I am the child. How can the child live without the Mother?"

13.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Śuddhā bhakti / शुद्धा भक्ति	pure love of God, seeking nothing in return
Brahmajñāna / ब्रह्मज्ञान	the knowledge of Brahman, the highest realisation
Bel / बेल	the wood-apple tree under which he practised austerities at Dakshineswar

13.2 HE ASKED FOR ONLY ONE THING

"To my Divine Mother I prayed only for pure love. I offered flowers at Her Lotus Feet and prayed to Her: 'Mother, here is Thy virtue, here is Thy vice. Take them both and grant me only pure love for Thee. Here is Thy knowledge, here is Thy ignorance. Take them both and grant me only pure love for Thee. Here is Thy purity, here is Thy impurity. Take them both, Mother, and grant me only pure love for Thee.'" Notice what is handed back: not only the vices, but the virtues; not only ignorance, but knowledge.

13.3 HE ALSO ARGUED, WEPT AND REFUSED

"How many austerities I practised under the bel-tree! I would lie down under it, crying to the Divine Mother, 'O Mother, reveal Thyself to me.' The tears would flow in torrents and soak my body." In another mood, like a small child making demands: "Mother, why haven't You

revealed to me that form of Yours, the form that bewitches the world? I pleaded with You so much for it." And in another: "Mother, I don't want Brahmajnana. I want to be merry. I want to play."

13.4 A CHILD NEEDS A MOTHER

"Mother, the paramahamsa is but a child. Doesn't a child need a mother? Therefore Thou art the Mother and I am the child. How can the child live without the Mother?" The relationship he taught is not formal worship at a distance. It is a child who complains, demands, sulks and adores, and who is entirely certain of being loved while doing all of it.

13.5 WHAT WE USUALLY ASK FOR

Most of our prayers ask for a change of circumstance. His asked for a change of relationship. Both are allowed, and children do ask for things. But it is worth noticing, once, what we would ask for if we could ask for only one thing, and whether that is the thing we actually need.

13.6 WHY HE REFUSED BRAHMAJNANA

To ask for love rather than the highest knowledge looks like choosing the lesser thing. In his case it was a choice to stay in relationship rather than to dissolve it, and he made it for others' sake as much as his own: someone had to remain able to speak. The request is also a diagnosis of our usual prayers. We ask for circumstances to change. He asked for the relationship to change, and let the circumstances be Hers.

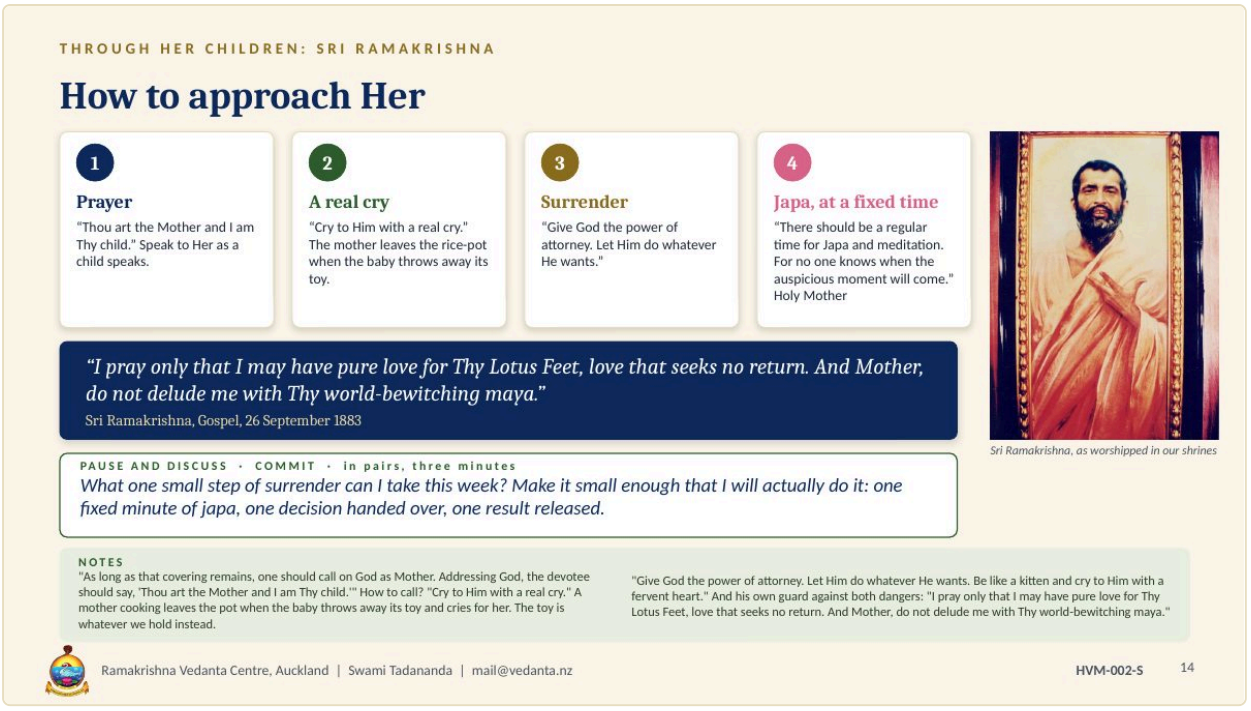
13.7 A CHILD WHO IS CERTAIN OF BEING LOVED

The tone of his prayers is worth more attention than their content. He complains, demands, sulks and adores, and throughout he is entirely certain of being loved. Many of us pray politely, as to an official who may refuse. He prayed as a child who has already been picked up once and knows it will happen again.

13.8 REFLECT

If I could ask Her for one thing only, what would it be? Is it what I truly need, or what I merely want just now?

How to approach Her



ON THE SLIDE

"As long as that covering remains, one should call on God as Mother. Addressing God, the devotee should say, 'Thou art the Mother and I am Thy child.'" How to call? "Cry to Him with a real cry." A mother cooking leaves the pot when the baby throws away its toy and cries for her. The toy is whatever we hold instead.

"Give God the power of attorney. Let Him do whatever He wants. Be like a kitten and cry to Him with a fervent heart." And his own guard against both dangers: "I pray only that I may have pure love for Thy Lotus Feet, love that seeks no return. And Mother, do not delude me with Thy world-bewitching maya."

14.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Japa / जप	repetition of the divine name
Prārthanā / प्रार्थना	prayer
Śaraṇāgati / शरणागति	taking refuge, surrender

14.2 CALL ON HER AS MOTHER

Sri Ramakrishna's advice to householders was direct: "As long as that covering remains, one should call on God as Mother. Addressing God, the devotee should say, 'Thou art the Mother and I am Thy child; Thou art the Master and I am Thy servant.'" The relationship of child to mother asks nothing of our qualifications. A child does not earn its mother.

14.3 CRY WITH A REAL CRY

When asked how one is to call, he said, "Cry to Him with a real cry," and sang: "Cry to your Mother Syama, with a real cry, O mind! And how can She hold Herself from you? How can Syama stay away?" He illustrated it with a baby: "A mother keeps on cooking while the baby is in bed sucking its toy. But when it throws the toy away and cries for her, she puts down the rice-pot and takes the baby in her arms and nurses it." The toy is whatever we hold instead.

14.4 GIVE HER THE POWER OF ATTORNEY

"Give God the power of attorney. Let Him do whatever He wants. Be like a kitten and cry to Him with a fervent heart." Surrender in a legal image: the authority to decide is signed over. And a prayer of his own that guards against the danger on both sides: "I pray only that I may have pure love for Thy Lotus Feet, love that seeks no return. And Mother, do not delude me with Thy world-bewitching maya."

14.5 THE NAME, AND A REGULAR TIME

The practical core of all this is japa, the repetition of Her name, with a fixed time for it. Holy Mother's instruction is the most usable sentence in this whole class: "There should be a regular time for the practice of Japa and meditation. For no one knows when the auspicious moment will come. It comes suddenly, one has no hint of it before hand." And for those who fail at it, which is all of us: "Whether the mind becomes steady or not, practise Japa."

14.6 THE FOUR DOORS: PRAYER, MEDITATION, SURRENDER, JAPA

These are not four separate disciplines to be fitted into a week. They are four aspects of one movement towards Her. Prayer is speaking; meditation is staying quiet long enough to be spoken to; japa is keeping the line open through the day; surrender is the attitude underneath all three. Of the four, japa is the one that fits into an ordinary working life without any rearrangement, which is why both Sri Ramakrishna and Holy Mother kept returning to it.

14.7 HOLY MOTHER'S PRACTICAL INSTRUCTIONS

Her advice is almost administrative in its plainness. "There should be a regular time for the practice of Japa and meditation. For no one knows when the auspicious moment will come." "Whether the mind becomes steady or not, practise Japa. It will be nice if you can perform a certain number of Japa daily." "You will succeed through practice. Don't give up your practice of Japa, even if your mind doesn't become steady." Notice that she assumes the mind will not be steady, and tells us to continue anyway.

14.8 REFLECT

What one small step of surrender can I take this week? Make it small enough that I will actually do it: one fixed minute of japa, one decision handed over, one result released.

Holy Mother: the gentle face



ON THE SLIDE

On the night of the Phalaharini Kali Puja in 1872 Sri Ramakrishna worshipped his own wife as the Divine Mother, and gave her the fruits of all his practice. He told her: "Think of her as the direct embodiment of the Divine Mother of the Universe." Asked why he left her behind, she said: "He left me behind this time for demonstrating that Motherhood to the world."

During his throat illness she dreamt: "I saw Mother Kali with her neck bent to one side. I asked Her, 'Mother, why do you stand like that?' She replied, 'It is because of this (pointing to the Master's sore in the throat); I too have it.'" The Mother of the universe, with a bent neck, in sympathy with one man's pain.

15.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Ṣoḍaśī Pūjā / षोडशी पूजा	the worship of the Divine Mother as Shodasi, performed by Sri Ramakrishna on Sarada Devi in 1872
Ādyāśakti / आद्याशक्ति	the primordial power; a name devotees used for Holy Mother
Jagaddhātrī / जगद्धात्री	the upholder of the world, a form of the Divine Mother worshipped at Jayrambati

15.2 SRI RAMAKRISHNA'S GIFT TO THE WORLD

On the night of the Phalaharini Kali Puja in 1872, Sri Ramakrishna worshipped his own wife, Sarada Devi, as the Divine Mother, and placed the fruits of all his spiritual practice at her feet. Afterwards he told her what to do with the articles of worship: "When you present your mother with these articles, don't think that she is an ordinary human being. Think of her as the direct embodiment of the Divine Mother of the Universe." The editors of her Gospel call that night the point at which Sarada, a village girl, was known in truth as the Holy Mother.

15.3 WHY SHE WAS LEFT BEHIND

A disciple asked why, unlike other incarnations, the Master had died first and left her behind. Her answer: "Do you know, my son, that the Master looked upon all in this world as Mother?

He left me behind this time for demonstrating that Motherhood to the world." Swami Vivekananda wrote to a brother disciple: "You have not yet understood the wonderful significance of Mother's life, none of you. But gradually you will know. Without Shakti there is no regeneration for the world."

15.4 THE DREAM OF KALI WITH A BENT NECK

During the Master's throat illness she had a dream, and told it simply: "I saw Mother Kali with her neck bent to one side. I asked Her, 'Mother, why do you stand like that?' She replied, 'It is because of this (pointing to the Master's sore in the throat); I too have it.'" The Mother of the universe, standing with a bent neck, in sympathy with one man's pain. For anyone who finds the fierce form hard to approach, this is the answer the tradition gives.

15.5 WHEN DEVOTEES NAMED HER

A devotee said that people called her Kali, Adyasakti, Bhagavati, and asked whether it was true. "Yes, true they are," said the Mother. When a disciple doubted the Deities she asked him in return: "Do you mean to say that there are no Deities like Kali, Krishna, Durga and the like?" She did not argue; she asked.

15.6 THE GENTLE FACE IS NOT A LESSER TEACHING

Some people meet the fierce form and cannot get past it. The tradition's answer is not to argue them into it but to show them the same Mother in Sarada Devi: a woman who cooked, who looked after a difficult household, who called everyone her child, and who said of herself that she was the mother of the wicked as well as the virtuous. Anyone who finds the sword impossible can begin here, and it is not a concession. Swami Vivekananda called her life the significance of which none of them had yet understood.

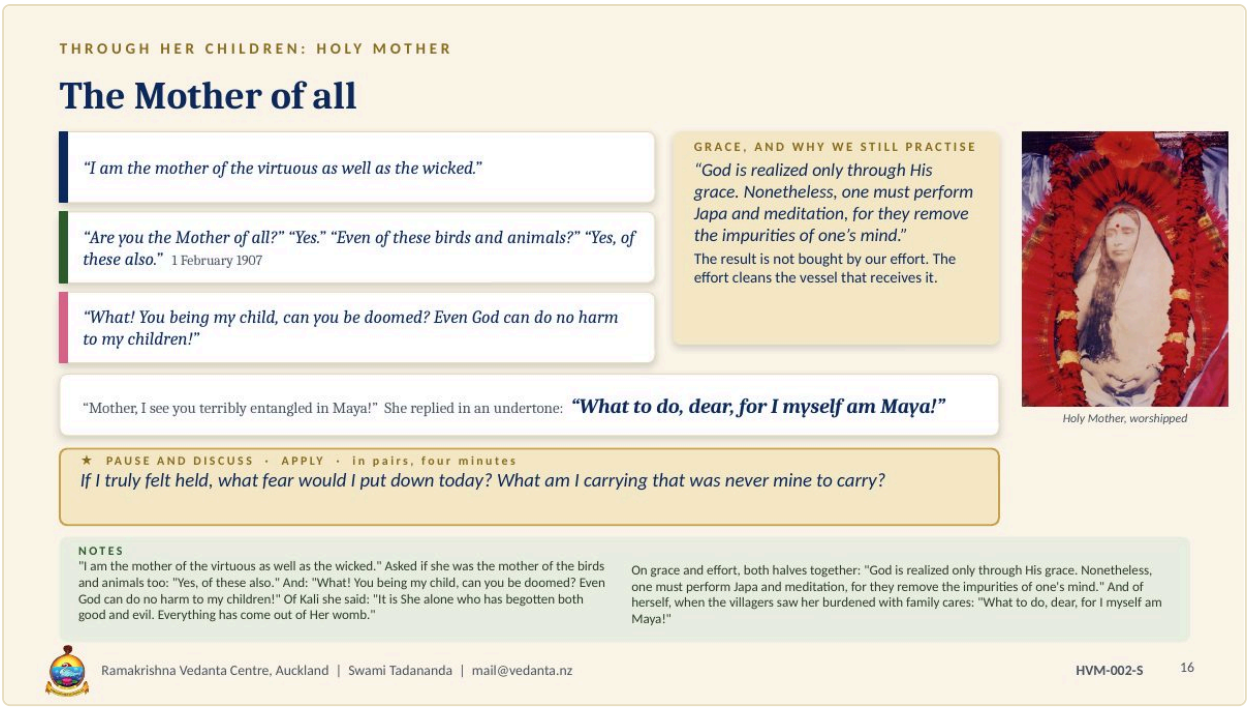
15.7 HER OWN WORDS ON WHO SHE IS

When a devotee listed the names given her, Kali, Adyasakti, Bhagavati, and asked whether they were true, she said simply, "Yes, true they are." When a disciple doubted the Deities, she asked him a question rather than making a claim: "Do you mean to say that there are no Deities like Kali, Krishna, Durga and the like?" And a woman devotee, told to see Mother Kali on the day of her initiation, wrote: "I reflected that in seeing the Holy Mother I had already seen the Mother Kali."

15.8 REFLECT

Who has been a mother to me, in the real sense of carrying me? How can I honour the Divine Mother in that person this week?

The Mother of all



ON THE SLIDE

"I am the mother of the virtuous as well as the wicked." Asked if she was the mother of the birds and animals too: "Yes, of these also." And: "What! You being my child, can you be doomed? Even God can do no harm to my children!" Of Kali she said: "It is She alone who has begotten both good and evil. Everything has come out of Her womb."

On grace and effort, both halves together: "God is realized only through His grace. Nonetheless, one must perform Japa and meditation, for they remove the impurities of one's mind." And of herself, when the villagers saw her burdened with family cares: "What to do, dear, for I myself am Maya!"

16.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Kṛpā / कृपा	grace
Māyā / माया	the power by which the one appears as many, and by which it is hidden
Śaraṇa / शरण	refuge

16.2 OF THE VIRTUOUS AND THE WICKED

Holy Mother said in conversation: "I am the mother of the virtuous as well as the wicked." Asked whether she was the mother of all, she said yes; asked whether of the birds and animals too, she said, "Yes, of these also." And of her children's fears: "What! You being my child, can you be doomed? Those who have come here, those who are my children, have already achieved liberation. Even God can do no harm to my children!" In her words, Kali, the Mother of the universe, "is the Mother of all. It is She alone who has begotten both good and evil. Everything has come out of Her womb."

16.3 GRACE, AND WHY WE STILL PRACTISE

Asked how one realizes God, by worship, japa or meditation, she first said, "By none of these," and then: "God is realized only through His grace. Nonetheless, one must perform Japa and

meditation, for they remove the impurities of one's mind." Both halves matter. The result is not bought by our effort, and the effort cleans the vessel that receives it. She added an image: "As one gets the fragrance of a flower by handling it or the scent of the sandalwood by rubbing it against a stone, similarly one becomes spiritually awakened by continuously contemplating on the Divine."

16.4 I MYSELF AM MAYA

Village women, seeing her burdened with family cares, said, "Mother, I see you terribly entangled in Maya!" She replied in an undertone, "What to do, dear, for I myself am Maya!" When a devotee flattered her as Mahamaya who had deluded them with husbands and children, she refused the compliment: "Don't speak like this, that I have kept others deluded! The sufferings of people bound in the world pain me very much. But what can I do, my child? They don't seek liberation."

16.5 TAKE REFUGE AND KEEP QUIET

Her instruction to those who could not manage much: "If you can't do even that, then take refuge in the Master. Remember this much: 'I have someone to look after me. There is certainly a Mother or Father.'" And: "Take refuge in me and keep quiet. And always remember that there is behind all of you one who in time will lead you to the abode of eternity."

16.6 SHE REFUSED THE FLATTERY

A devotee once praised her as Mahamaya who had deluded them all with husbands and children. She would not have it: "Don't speak like this, that I have kept others deluded! The sufferings of people bound in the world pain me very much. But what can I do, my child? They don't seek liberation." It is a precise theology in four sentences. The binding is real, She feels it, and the one thing She will not override is our own unwillingness to be free.

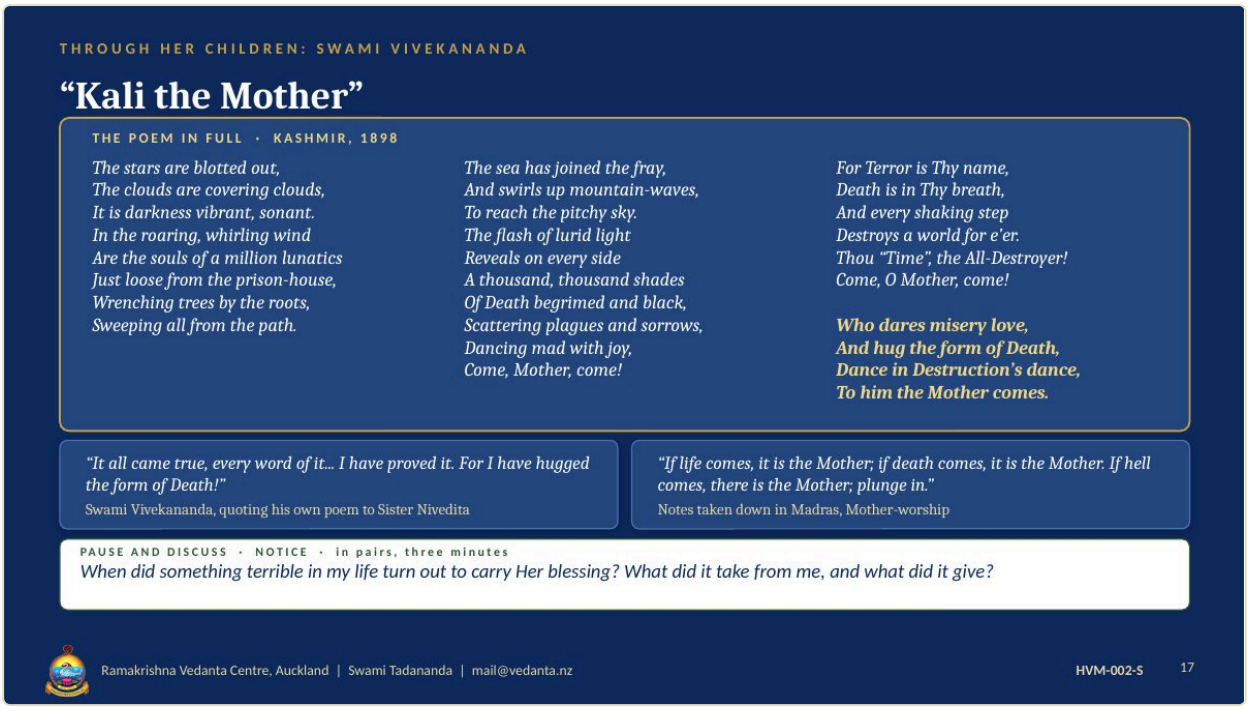
16.7 FOR THOSE WHO CAN DO VERY LITTLE

Her instruction to the overwhelmed is the gentlest in our literature. "If you can't do even that, then take refuge in the Master. Remember this much: 'I have someone to look after me. There is certainly a Mother or Father.'" And: "Take refuge in me and keep quiet. And always remember that there is behind all of you one who in time will lead you to the abode of eternity." There is no minimum qualification here, and no task that can be failed.

16.8 REFLECT

If I truly felt held, what fear would I put down today? What am I carrying that was never mine to carry?

“Kali the Mother”



ON THE SLIDE

His poem of 1898: "The stars are blotted out, The clouds are covering clouds, It is darkness vibrant, sonant." It names Her without softening: "For Terror is Thy name, Death is in Thy breath, Thou 'Time', the All-Destroyer!" And ends: "Who dares misery love, And hug the form of Death, Dance in Destruction's dance, To him the Mother comes."

Years later he quoted his own lines and broke off: "It all came true, every word of it... To him the Mother does indeed come. I have proved it. For I have hugged the form of Death!" And: "If life comes, it is the Mother; if death comes, it is the Mother. If hell comes, there is the Mother; plunge in."

17.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Kāla / काल	time, and the All-Destroyer; the root of the name Kālī
Mahākāla / महाकाल	great Time, Siva, who lies beneath Her feet in the image

17.2 THE POEM

Swami Vivekananda wrote "Kali the Mother" in 1898. It begins: "The stars are blotted out, The clouds are covering clouds, It is darkness vibrant, sonant." It names Her without softening anything: "For Terror is Thy name, Death is in Thy breath, And every shaking step Destroys a world for e'er. Thou 'Time', the All-Destroyer! Come, O Mother, come!" And it ends: "Who dares misery love, And hug the form of Death, Dance in Destruction's dance, To him the Mother comes."

17.3 HE MEANT IT LITERALLY

Years later, quoting his own poem, he broke off to say: "It all came true, every word of it." And then: "To him the Mother does indeed come. I have proved it. For I have hugged the form of Death!" His recorded sayings carry the same note: "How few have dared to worship Death or

Kali! Let us worship Death! Let us embrace the Terrible, because it is terrible, not asking that it be toned down."

17.4 WHY ANY OF THIS IS GOOD NEWS

Because the alternative is a God who is responsible only for the pleasant things, which leaves us alone precisely when we most need company. "If life comes, it is the Mother; if death comes, it is the Mother. If heaven comes, She is. If hell comes, there is the Mother; plunge in." During the plague in Calcutta, with people frantic and soldiers in the streets, he said: "There are some who scoff at the existence of Kali. Yet today She is out there amongst the people." And in the plague manifesto: "The Mother of the Universe is Herself the support of the helpless. The Mother is assuring us: 'Fear not! Fear not!'"

17.5 A BLESSING FOR THIS SEASON

Writing to a brother disciple on a night sacred to the Divine Mother in November 1899, he said: "I bless you all; today, on this day sacred to the Divine Mother, on this night, may the Mother dance in your hearts and bring infinite strength to your arms." That is a fair blessing for our Diwali.

17.6 WHY THIS IS GOOD NEWS AND NOT MORBID

A God who is responsible only for the pleasant half of life leaves us alone in the other half, which is precisely where company is needed. By naming death, terror and time as the Mother, the tradition says that nothing in human experience falls outside Her, and therefore nothing in it has to be faced alone. During the Calcutta plague, with people frantic and soldiers in the streets, he said: "There are some who scoff at the existence of Kali. Yet today She is out there amongst the people." The plague manifesto adds: "The Mother of the Universe is Herself the support of the helpless. The Mother is assuring us: 'Fear not! Fear not!'"

17.7 A BLESSING FOR THE SEASON

Writing to a brother disciple on a night sacred to the Divine Mother in November 1899, he wrote: "I bless you all; today, on this day sacred to the Divine Mother, on this night, may the Mother dance in your hearts and bring infinite strength to your arms." It is a fair blessing to carry into our own Diwali, and the last slide gives it again.

17.8 REFLECT

When did something terrible in my life turn out to carry Her blessing? What did it take from me, and what did it give?

Vidya maya and Avidya maya



ON THE SLIDE

"Bondage and liberation are both of Her making. By Her Maya worldly people become entangled in lust and greed, and again, through Her grace they attain their liberation." "Mahamaya contains both Vidya-maya, the illusion of knowledge, and Avidya-maya, the illusion of ignorance."

Vidya-maya builds "the taste for holy company, knowledge, devotion, love, and renunciation". Avidya-maya is the objects of the senses, which "make one forget God". And the reason we worship Her: "God is near us, but it is not possible to know Him because Mahamaya stands between."

18.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Mahāmāyā / महामाया	the great Maya; the Divine Mother as the power that both veils and reveals
Vidyā-māyā / विद्यामाया	the aspect that leads towards knowledge and devotion
Avidyā-māyā / अविद्यामाया	the aspect that scatters us among the objects of the senses

18.2 THE SAME POWER BINDS AND FREES

Sri Ramakrishna: "Bondage and liberation are both of Her making. By Her Maya worldly people become entangled in 'lust and greed', and again, through Her grace they attain their liberation. She is called Saviour, and the remover of the bondage that binds one to the world." The power that holds us is not a rival force. It is the Mother, in another mood.

18.3 TWO KINDS OF MAYA

"This universe is created by the Mahamaya of God. Mahamaya contains both Vidya-maya, the illusion of knowledge, and Avidya-maya, the illusion of ignorance. Through the help of Vidya-maya one cultivates such virtues as the taste for holy company, knowledge, devotion, love, and renunciation." And of the other: "Avidya-maya consists of the five elements and the objects of the five senses, form, flavour, smell, touch, and sound. These make one forget God." Both are Her. One leads home; the other scatters us.

18.4 THE DOOR AND THE KEY

"God Himself is Mahamaya, who deludes the world with Her illusion. She has spread this veil of ignorance before our eyes. We can go into the inner chamber only when She lets us pass through the door." And: "One attains the vision of God if Mahamaya steps aside from the door. Mahamaya's grace is necessary: hence the worship of Shakti. You see, God is near us, but it is not possible to know Him because Mahamaya stands between." This is the practical reason for worshipping the Mother: She holds the key.

18.5 HIDE AND SEEK

A Brahmo devotee asked exactly that. The answer was a game of hide and seek: "That is Her will. She wants to continue playing with Her created beings. In a game of hide-and-seek the running about soon stops if in the beginning all the players touch the 'granny'." And a song: "Out of a hundred thousand kites, at best but one or two break free; And Thou dost laugh and clap Thy hands, O Mother, watching them!" It is said lightly, and it is not a cruel picture: the kites that break free do so by Her hand on the string.

18.6 SORTING OUR OWN DAY

The useful exercise is to sort one ordinary day into the two columns. What in today drew me towards Her: a kind act, a book, a conversation, a quiet half hour. What scattered me: the thing I could not stop scrolling, the resentment I rehearsed. Both were Her. Only one was Her leading us home.

18.7 WHY SHE KEEPS US BOUND AT ALL

A Brahmo devotee asked exactly this, and the answer was a children's game: "That is Her will. She wants to continue playing with Her created beings. In a game of hide-and-seek the running about soon stops if in the beginning all the players touch the granny." Then a song: "Out of a hundred thousand kites, at best but one or two break free; And Thou dost laugh and clap Thy hands, O Mother, watching them!" The picture is not cruel. The kite that breaks free does so by the hand that holds the string.

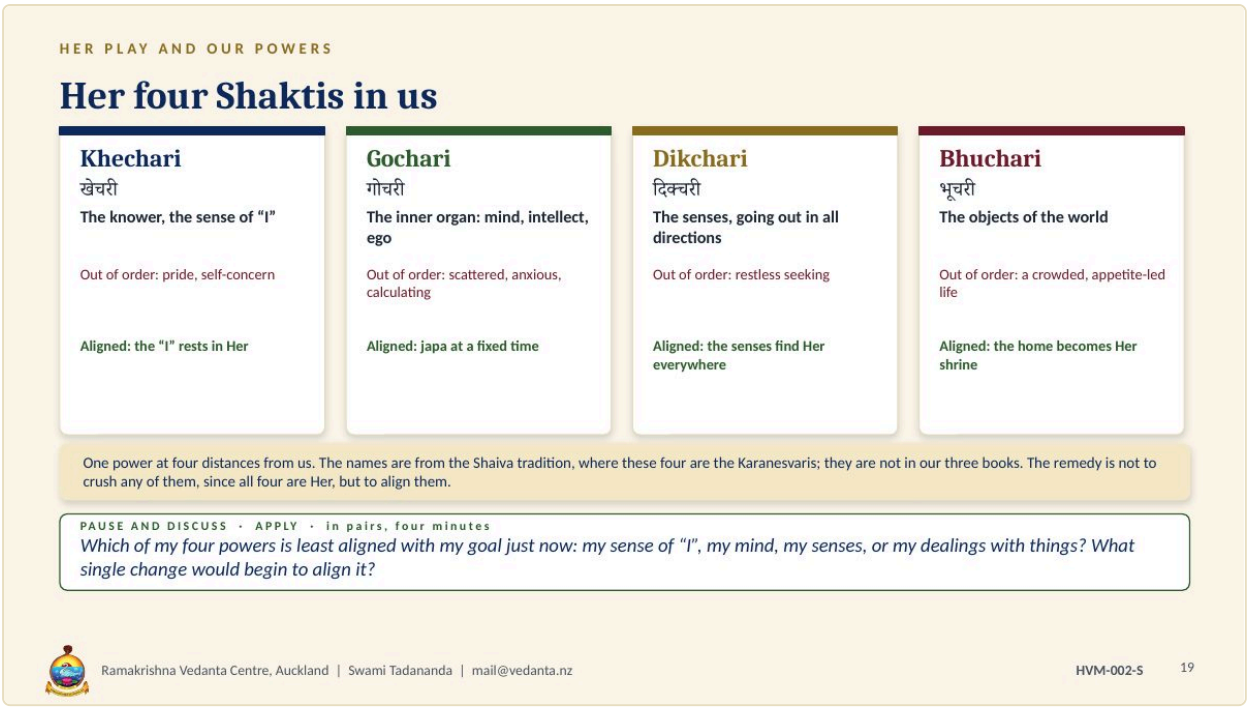
18.8 SORTING ONE DAY INTO TWO COLUMNS

The practical use of this teaching is an exercise, not a doctrine. At the end of one ordinary day, list what drew you towards Her: a kind act, a book, a conversation, a quiet half hour, a piece of music. Then list what scattered you: the thing you could not stop scrolling, the resentment you rehearsed, the second hour of television. Both columns are Hers. Only one of them is Her leading you home. Nothing in the second column needs to be hated; it needs to be seen.

18.9 REFLECT

Which pulls in my day lead me towards Her, and which make me forget Her? Name one of each, honestly.

Her four Shaktis in us



ON THE SLIDE

The Shaiva tradition names four classes of the Mother's power as they work in us. Khechari moves in the sky of consciousness and relates to the knower, the sense of "I". Gochari works in the inner organ: mind, intellect and ego. Dikchari goes out in all directions through the senses. Bhuchari rests in the objects of the world.

One power, at four distances from us. Pride is Khechari turned on itself; a scattered mind is Gochari out of order; restless seeking is Dikchari loose; a crowded, appetite-led life is Bhuchari turned into a prison. The remedy is not to crush them, since all four are Her, but to align them.

19.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Khecarī / खेचरी	moving in the sky: the power at the level of the knower, the sense of 'I'
Gocarī / गोचरी	the power at the level of the inner organ: mind, intellect and ego
Dikcarī / दिक्चरी	moving in the directions: the power at the level of the outer senses
Bhūcarī / भूचरी	moving on the earth: the power at the level of existing objects
Karaṇeśvarī / करणेश्वरी	the goddesses of the instruments; the collective name for these four

19.2 FOUR POWERS, ONE MOTHER

The Shaiva tradition names four classes of the Mother's power as they work in each of us, and calls them the Karanesvaris, the goddesses of the instruments. Khechari moves in the sky of consciousness and relates to the knower, the sense of "I". Gochari works in the inner organ, the mind, the intellect and the ego. Dikchari goes out in all directions through the senses. Bhuchari rests in the existing objects of the world. One power, working at four distances from us.

19.3 WHY IT IS USEFUL

Because it tells us where to look. Most of our trouble can be located in one of the four. Pride and self-concern are Khechari turned on itself. A scattered, anxious, calculating mind is Gochari out of order. Senses that cannot stop seeking are Dikchari running loose. A life crowded with possessions and appetites is Bhuchari turned into a prison. The remedy is not to crush any of them, because all four are Her, but to align them.

19.4 NOT IN OUR THREE BOOKS

These names do not occur in the Gospel of Sri Ramakrishna, the Gospel of Holy Mother or the Complete Works of Swami Vivekananda. They belong to the Shaiva and Tantric tradition, and are presented here as that tradition's teaching, not as a quotation from our own books. The teaching they carry is the same one our books give in plain words: the whole of us, from the sense of "I" down to the things on our desk, belongs to Her and can either bind us or carry us.

19.5 ALIGNMENT, NOT SUPPRESSION

To align Khechari is to let the "I" rest in Her instead of in pride. To align Gochari is to turn the mind towards Her, chiefly through japa and a regular time for it. To align Dikchari is to let the senses go out to find Her everywhere, which is what Sri Ramakrishna's vision in the temple describes. To align Bhuchari is to make the home and its things into Her shrine, which is exactly what a festival like Diwali is for.

19.6 WHERE THIS TEACHING COMES FROM

These four names do not occur in the Gospel of Sri Ramakrishna, the Gospel of Holy Mother or the Complete Works of Swami Vivekananda. They belong to the Shaiva and Tantric tradition, where the four are known as the Karanesvaris, the presiding powers of the instruments of knowledge, and they are given here as that tradition's teaching. The substance is the same as our own books teach in plainer words: the whole of us, from the sense of 'I' down to the objects on the table, is Her power, and each part can either bind us or carry us.

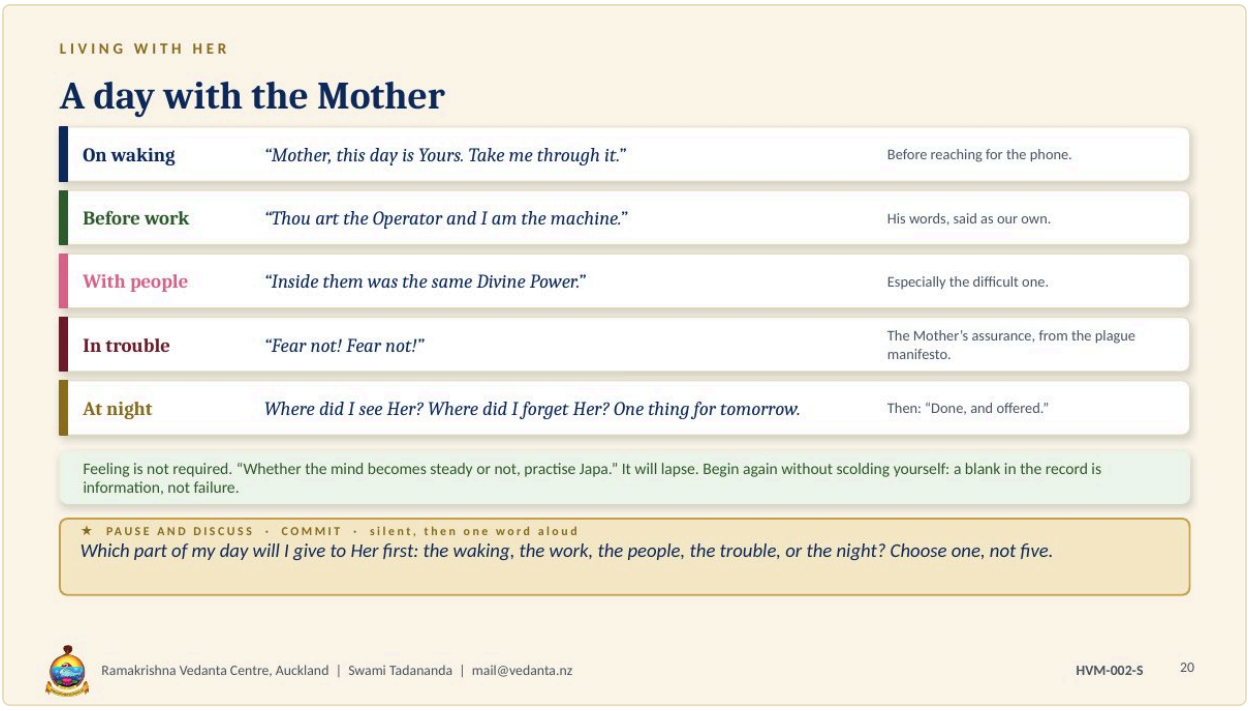
19.7 ALIGNING THE FOUR, IN PRACTICE

Khechari is aligned when the sense of 'I' rests in Her rather than in achievement, which is what 'Thou art the Operator and I am the machine' does. Gochari is aligned by japa at a fixed time, which gives the mind one place to return to. Dikchari is aligned when the senses are used to find Her, which is Sri Ramakrishna's vision in the temple: the floor, the vessels, the door-sill. Bhuchari is aligned when the home and its things are treated as Her shrine, which is exactly what a festival such as Diwali is for. The prayer on slide 22 asks for all four in one breath.

19.8 REFLECT

Which of my four powers is least aligned with my goal just now: my sense of "I", my mind, my senses, or my dealings with things? What single change would begin to align it?

A day with the Mother



ON THE SLIDE

On waking, before the phone: "Mother, this day is Yours. Take me through it." Before a piece of work: "Thou art the Operator and I am the machine." On meeting a difficult person, remember that "inside them was the same Divine Power". In trouble, the shortest prayer we have: "Fear not! Fear not!"

Before sleep, three lines: where did I see Her today, where did I forget Her, one thing for tomorrow. Then hand the day back: "Done, and offered." The lines are short on purpose. Long prayers are not said when we are busy, and a line that is actually said beats a page that is not.

20.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Smaraṇa / स्मरण	remembrance of God, kept up through the day
Nivedana / निवेदन	offering, handing something over to the Divine

20.2 THE AIM: HER PRESENCE IN THOUGHT, WORD AND DEED

Everything so far comes down to one practical question. How do we live a single day in Her company? The answer is not more religious activity. It is a line of connection at the ordinary joints of the day: waking, working, meeting people, meeting trouble, and sleeping. Keep the lines short enough to say in one breath, because long prayers are not said when we are busy.

20.3 MORNING, WORK, PEOPLE

On waking, before reaching for the phone: "Mother, this day is Yours. Take me through it." Before beginning a piece of work: "Thou art the Operator and I am the machine," which are his words, said as our own. On meeting a difficult person, remember that "inside them was the same Divine Power". It is not necessary to feel anything. The line is said, and the feeling follows in its own time, or does not, and the line is still said.

20.4 TROUBLE, AND NIGHT

In trouble, the shortest prayer we have is the one from the plague manifesto: "Fear not! Fear not!" Before sleep, three lines of review: where did I see Her today, where did I forget Her, and one thing for tomorrow. End by handing the day back: "Done, and offered."

20.5 WHAT MAKES THIS WORK

Two things. The first is a fixed time for japa, however short, because, as Holy Mother said, no one knows when the auspicious moment will come. The second is a willingness to begin again each time it lapses, without scolding ourselves. "You will succeed through practice. Don't give up your practice of Japa, even if your mind doesn't become steady."

20.6 FEELING IS NOT REQUIRED

A common obstacle: people stop saying these lines because they feel nothing while saying them. Holy Mother's advice removes the obstacle. "Whether the mind becomes steady or not, practise Japa." The line is said; the feeling comes in its own time, or it does not, and the line is still said. The practice is the saying, not the feeling, and anyone who waits for the feeling before practising will wait a long time.

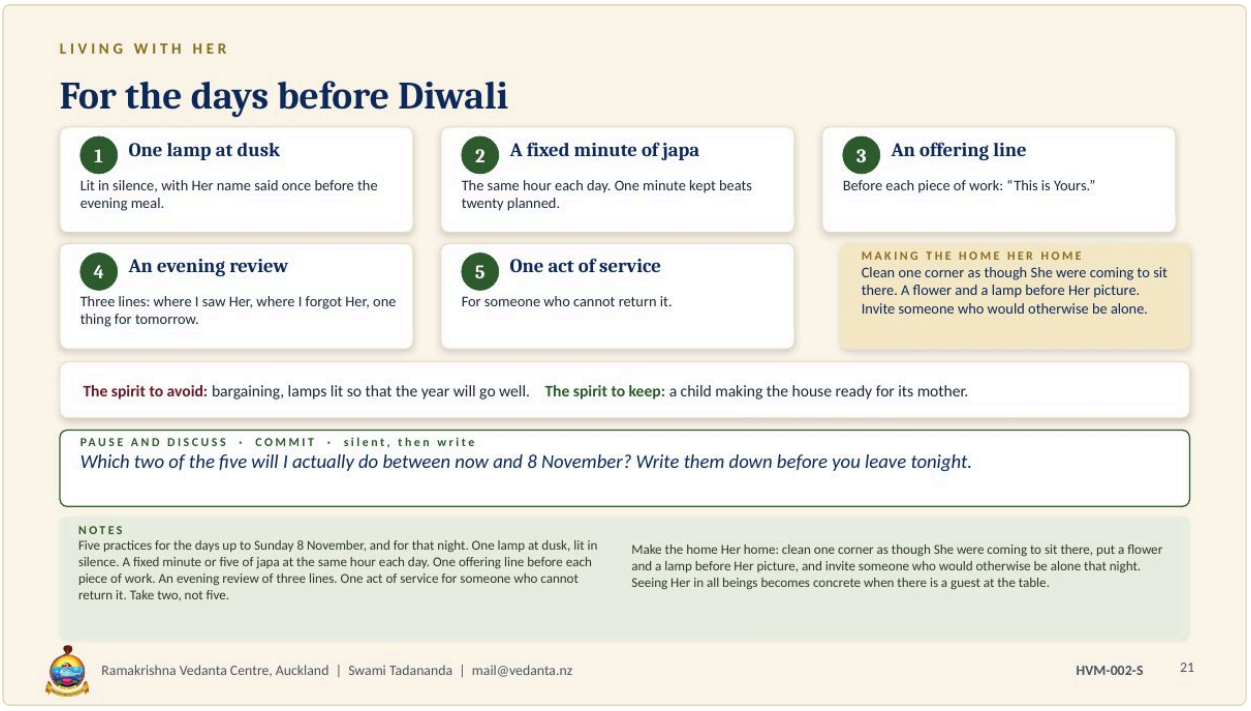
20.7 WHAT TO DO WHEN IT LAPSES

It will lapse, usually within a week. The only useful response is to begin again without any self-reproach, because self-reproach takes more time and energy than the practice itself. "You will succeed through practice. Don't give up your practice of Japa, even if your mind doesn't become steady." A blank in the record is information, not failure.

20.8 REFLECT

Which part of my day will I give to Her first: the waking, the work, the people, the trouble, or the night? Choose one, not five.

For the days before Diwali



ON THE SLIDE

Five practices for the days up to Sunday 8 November, and for that night. One lamp at dusk, lit in silence. A fixed minute or five of japa at the same hour each day. One offering line before each piece of work. An evening review of three lines. One act of service for someone who cannot return it. Take two, not five.

Make the home Her home: clean one corner as though She were coming to sit there, put a flower and a lamp before Her picture, and invite someone who would otherwise be alone that night. Seeing Her in all beings becomes concrete when there is a guest at the table.

21.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Dīpa / दीप	lamp
Sevā / सेवा	service
Ārati / आरती	the waving of lights before the Divine, at dusk

21.2 THE DAYS BEFORE THE NEW MOON

Five simple practices for the days up to Sunday 8 November, and for that night. Take two, not all five. One lamp at dusk, lit in silence, with Her name said once before the first bite of the evening meal. One fixed minute, or five, of japa at the same hour each day. One offering line before each piece of work. One evening review of three lines. And one act of service, however small, done for someone who cannot return it.

21.3 MAKING THE HOME HER HOME

A festival is permission to do outwardly what we mean inwardly. Clean one corner of the house as though She were coming to sit there, because the tradition says She is. Put a flower and a lamp before Her picture. Invite someone who would otherwise be alone that night. Sri Ramakrishna's whole teaching about seeing Her in all beings becomes very concrete when there is a guest at the table.

21.4 THE SPIRIT TO AVOID, AND THE SPIRIT TO KEEP

The spirit to avoid is bargaining: lamps lit so that the year will go well. The spirit to keep is a child making the house ready for its mother. Holy Mother's instruction to a woman who felt unfit even to enter the shrine covers all our hesitations: "Come, I shall initiate you. Surrender everything at the feet of Sri Ramakrishna. Why should you fear?"

21.5 THE DIWALI CARD

The appendix of the Study Companion has a one page card with the prayer, these five practices and three questions, meant to be cut out and kept where it will be seen, on the fridge or beside the shrine. Something kept in sight is done; something kept in a folder is not.

21.6 THE SPIRIT TO AVOID, AND THE ONE TO KEEP

The spirit to avoid is bargaining: lamps lit so that the year will go well, worship as an insurance payment. The spirit to keep is a child making the house ready for its mother. Holy Mother's words to a woman who felt unfit even to enter the shrine cover all our hesitations: "Come, I shall initiate you. Surrender everything at the feet of Sri Ramakrishna. Why should you fear?"

21.7 KEEPING IT WHERE IT WILL BE SEEN

The appendix of this companion has a one page Diwali card with the prayer, the five practices and three questions, meant to be cut out and kept on the fridge or beside the shrine. This is not a decorative suggestion. A practice kept in sight is done; a practice kept in a folder is not. Those who want to go further can keep a simple tick list for the five days, as in the HVM-001 tracker.

21.8 REFLECT

Which two of the five will I actually do between now and 8 November? Write them down before you leave tonight.

Our prayer to the Mother



ON THE SLIDE

We begin with the verse from the Argala Stotram, recited before the Devi Mahatmya. It names Her as victory and as the auspicious, as Kali and Bhadrakali and Kapalini, and in the same breath as the gracious one, as forbearance, and as the upholder of all. The fierce names and the gentle names belong to one Mother.

Then our own prayer, written for this class: that the four Shaktis in us be aligned to the goal and not bind us in avidya maya, and that She keep us as children in Her lap. Say it together once, slowly. Then take it home on the Diwali card and say it at the lamp each evening until the new moon.

22.1 VERSE

ARGALA STOTRAM, VERSE 2

जयन्ती मङ्गला काली भद्रकाली कपालिनी ।

दुर्गा शिवा क्षमा धात्री स्वाहा स्वधा नमोऽस्तु ते ॥ २ ॥

jayantī maṅgalā kālī bhadrakālī kapālinī
durgā śivā kṣamā dhātrī svāhā svadhā namo 'stu te

Salutations to Thee, Jayanti the ever victorious, Mangala the auspicious, Kali, Bhadrakali, Kapalini; Durga, Shiva the gracious, Kshama the forgiving, Dhatri who upholds all, Svaha and Svadha.

22.2 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Jayantī / जयन्ती	the ever victorious
Maṅgalā / मङ्गला	the auspicious, the bestower of good
Kapālinī / कपालिनी	She who wears the garland of skulls
Kṣamā / क्षमा	forbearance, forgiveness

Dhātrī / धात्री	the upholder and nourisher of all beings

22.3 THE PRAYER

The prayer that follows is our own, written for this class. Its four middle lines ask that the four Shaktis be aligned: that the sense of "I" rest in Her and not in pride, that mind and intellect be turned towards Her, that the senses go out to find Her rather than to gather what binds, and that the world of things become Her shrine and not our prison. Then it asks, in Sri Ramakrishna's own words, that She take our knowledge and our ignorance both, and grant us pure love.

22.4 HOW TO USE IT

Say it together tonight, slowly, once. Then take it home on the Diwali card and say it at the lamp each evening until the new moon. A prayer said aloud in a room of people has a different weight from one read silently, and a prayer said daily for a week has a different weight again.

22.5 ONE LINE FOR THE DAY

For those who want something shorter to carry: "Mother, Thou art the doer and I am Thine. Be in this thought, this word, this act." Said at a desk, at a sink, or in a car, it is enough.

22.6 THE TEXT OF THE PRAYER

O Mother, Thou art Brahman and Thou art Shakti. Thou hast become this universe, and Thou hast become us. We are Thy children. Keep us in Thy lap and hold our hands. Mother, Thou art the power within all our powers. Let Khechari, the sense of "I" in us, rest in Thee and not in pride. Let Gochari, our mind and intellect, be turned towards Thee and not scattered. Let Dikchari, our senses, go out to find Thee everywhere and not to gather what binds. Let Bhuchari, the world of things around us, become Thy shrine and not our prison. Take our ignorance and our knowledge, our good and our bad, and grant us pure love for Thee. Let not Thy avidya maya bind us; let Thy vidya maya lead us home. Be in our thoughts, in our words and in our hands, this Diwali and every day. Mother, light Thy lamp in us, and let it never go out.

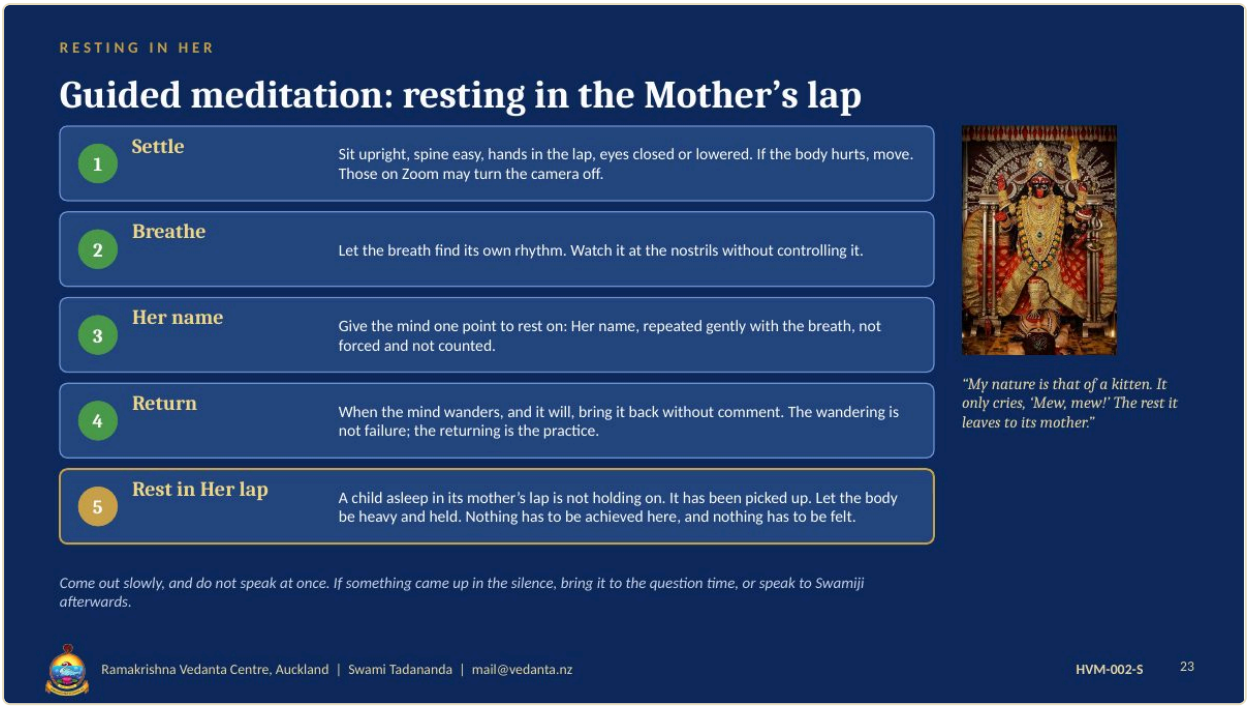
22.7 ONE LINE TO CARRY

For those who want something shorter for the working day: "Mother, Thou art the doer and I am Thine. Be in this thought, this word, this act." Said at a desk, at a sink or in a car, it is enough. It carries the teaching of slide 11 in fourteen words, and it can be said without closing the eyes or stopping work.

22.8 REFLECT

Which line of this prayer is mine, the one that says what I would have said if I had found the words?

Guided meditation: resting in the Mother’s lap



ON THE SLIDE

Fifteen to twenty minutes of sitting, guided aloud, with long silences. Sit upright with the spine easy and the hands in the lap, eyes closed or lowered. If the body hurts, move. Those joining on Zoom may turn the camera off.

We settle the body, let the breath find its own rhythm, watch it at the nostrils without controlling it, and then give the mind one point to rest on: Her name, repeated gently, not forced and not counted. When the mind wanders, bring it back without comment. The wandering is not failure; the returning is the practice.

23.1 WORD BY WORD AND KEY TERMS

Dhyāna / ध्यान	meditation
Āsana / आसन	the seat, the posture for sitting
Mantra / मन्त्र	the sacred name or formula repeated in japa

23.2 WHAT WE WILL DO

About fifteen to twenty minutes of sitting, guided aloud, with long silences. Sit upright with the spine easy, hands in the lap, eyes closed or lowered. If the body hurts, move; discomfort is not part of the practice. Those on Zoom can turn the camera off.

23.3 THE SHAPE OF THE SITTING

We begin as we always do: settling the body, letting the breath find its own rhythm, and watching the breath at the nostrils without controlling it. Then the mind is given one point to rest on, Her name, repeated gently with the breath, not forced and not counted. When the mind wanders, and it will, bring it back without comment. The wandering is not failure; the returning is the practice.

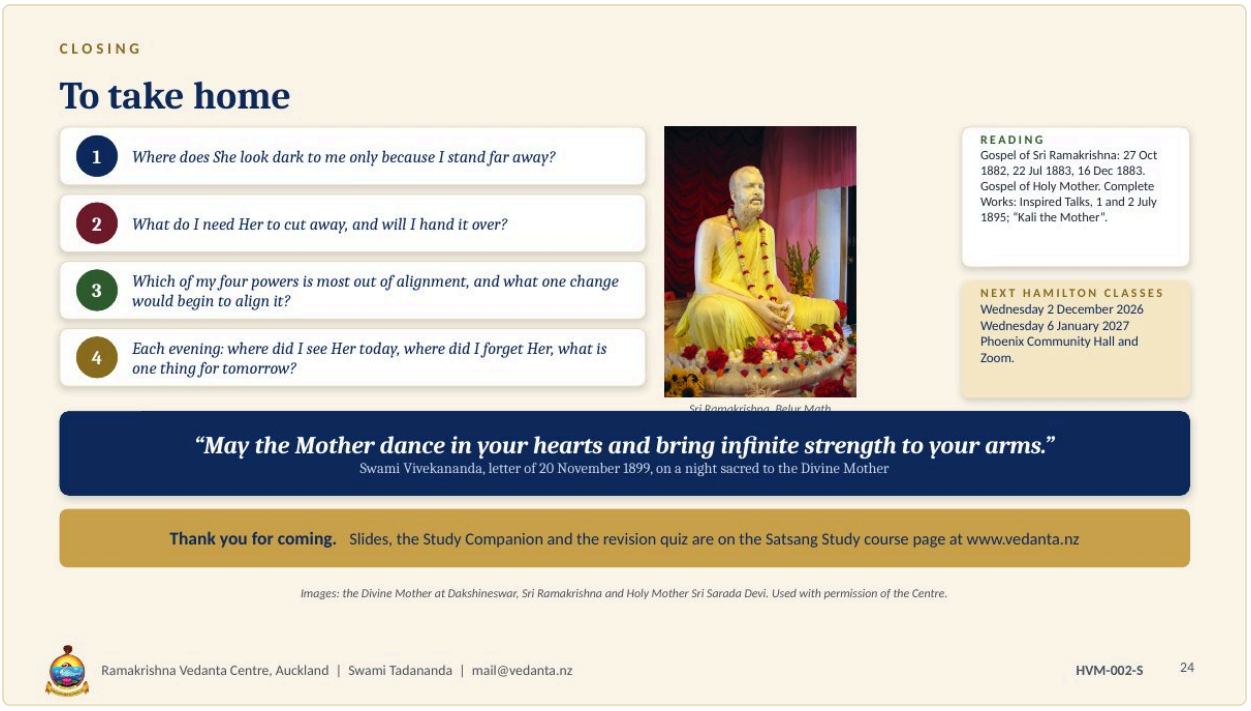
23.4 RESTING IN THE MOTHER'S LAP

In the last part of the sitting we use the image this class has been building towards. A child asleep in its mother's lap is not holding on; it has been picked up. Let the body be heavy and held. Nothing has to be achieved in this part of the sitting, and nothing has to be felt. If the image does not come, return to Her name and let the rest go. Sri Ramakrishna's kitten does not cling. It cries once, and it is carried.

23.5 AFTERWARDS

Come out slowly, and do not speak at once. Sitting quietly for a minute after the guidance stops is often the most valuable minute. If something came up in the silence that you would like to ask about, bring it to the question time. There is no need to describe it in front of others if you would rather not; speak to Swami Tadananda afterwards.

To take home



ON THE SLIDE

Four questions to take home: where does She look dark to me only because I stand far away? What do I need Her to cut away, and will I hand it over? Which of my four powers is most out of alignment, and what one change would begin to align it? And each evening: where did I see Her today, where did I forget Her, what is one thing for tomorrow?

Next Hamilton classes: Wednesday 2 December 2026 and Wednesday 6 January 2027, Phoenix Community Hall and Zoom. New Lynn satsangs continue fortnightly on Sundays. Dates and registration are on our website. Thank you for coming, and for the questions.

24.1 QUESTIONS TO TAKE HOME

Four questions for the days before Diwali, one for each week if you prefer. Where in my life does She look dark only because I stand far away? What do I need Her to cut away, and am I willing to hand it over? Which of my four powers, my sense of "I", my mind, my senses, my dealings with things, is most out of alignment, and what one change would begin to align it? And, each evening: where did I see Her today, where did I forget Her, and what is one thing for tomorrow?

24.2 READING

From our own books, and all of them are quoted in these notes: the Gospel of Sri Ramakrishna, especially the conversations of 27 October 1882 with Keshab Sen and of 22 July 1883 with Govinda, where the image is explained; the Gospel of Holy Mother; and from the Complete Works of Swami Vivekananda, the Inspired Talks of 1 and 2 July 1895 and the poem "Kali the Mother". The Study Companion gives the sources section by section.

24.3 NEXT CLASSES

Hamilton meets on the first Wednesday of each month: Wednesday 2 December 2026 and Wednesday 6 January 2027, at Phoenix Community Hall, Frankton, and on Zoom. The New

Lynn satsangs continue fortnightly on Sundays. Dates and registration are on our website.

24.4 THANK YOU

Thank you for coming, for sitting in silence with strangers, and for the questions. May the Mother dance in your hearts this Diwali and bring infinite strength to your arms.

24.5 READING, WITH SOURCES

All the quotations in this companion come from our own three books. In the Gospel of Sri Ramakrishna, the conversation with Keshab Sen of 27 October 1882 and the conversation with Govinda of 22 July 1883 contain most of the teaching on the image and on Brahman and Shakti; the vision in the Kali temple is in the conversation of 16 December 1883. In the Gospel of Holy Mother, see the records of Swami Arupananda and of Sarayubala Devi. In the Complete Works of Swami Vivekananda, see the Inspired Talks of 1 and 2 July 1895, the lecture 'My Master', the poem 'Kali the Mother', and the letter to Swami Shivananda on Holy Mother. The Gospel of Sri Ramakrishna and the Gospel of Holy Mother are available in full in the courses on our website.

24.6 A BLESSING

"I bless you all; today, on this day sacred to the Divine Mother, on this night, may the Mother dance in your hearts and bring infinite strength to your arms." Swami Vivekananda, in a letter of 20 November 1899, on a night sacred to the Divine Mother.

The Diwali card

Cut out or copy these two pages and keep them where they will be seen, on the fridge or beside the shrine. Something kept in sight is done; something kept in a folder is not.

A1.1 THE VERSE

ARGALA STOTRAM, VERSE 2, RECITED BEFORE THE DEVI MAHATMYA

जयन्ती मङ्गला काली भद्रकाली कपालिनी ।
दुर्गा शिवा क्षमा धात्री स्वाहा स्वधा नमोऽस्तु ते ॥ २ ॥

jayantī maṅgalā kālī bhadrakālī kapālinī
durgā śivā kṣamā dhātrī svāhā svadhā namo 'stu te

Salutations to Thee, Jayanti the ever victorious, Mangala the auspicious, Kali, Bhadrakali, Kapalini; Durga, Shiva the gracious, Kshama the forgiving, Dhatri who upholds all, Svaha and Svadha.

A1.2 OUR PRAYER

O Mother, Thou art Brahman and Thou art Shakti. Thou hast become this universe, and Thou hast become us. We are Thy children. Keep us in Thy lap and hold our hands.

Mother, Thou art the power within all our powers.

Let Khechari, the sense of "I" in us, rest in Thee and not in pride.

Let Gochari, our mind and intellect, be turned towards Thee and not scattered.

Let Dikchari, our senses, go out to find Thee everywhere and not to gather what binds.

Let Bhuchari, the world of things around us, become Thy shrine and not our prison.

Take our ignorance and our knowledge, our good and our bad, and grant us pure love for Thee. Let not Thy avidya maya bind us; let Thy vidya maya lead us home.

Be in our thoughts, in our words and in our hands, this Diwali and every day. Mother, light Thy lamp in us, and let it never go out.

For the working day: "Mother, Thou art the doer and I am Thine. Be in this thought, this word, this act."

The practice card

The second half of the card. Keep it beside the first, or on the back of it.

A2.1 FIVE PRACTICES FOR THE DAYS BEFORE DIWALI

☐ **One lamp at dusk** Lit in silence, with Her name said once before the evening meal.

☐ **A fixed minute of japa** The same hour each day. One minute kept beats twenty planned.

☐ **An offering line** Before each piece of work: “This is Yours.”

☐ **An evening review** Three lines: where I saw Her, where I forgot Her, one thing for tomorrow.

☐ **One act of service** For someone who cannot return it.

A2.2 TICK LIST, WEDNESDAY 4 TO SUNDAY 8 NOVEMBER 2026

Practice	Wed 4	Thu 5	Fri 6	Sat 7	Sun 8
One lamp at dusk					
A fixed minute of japa					
An offering line					
An evening review					
One act of service					

A2.3 THREE QUESTIONS TO CARRY

1. Where does She look dark to me only because I stand far away?
2. What do I need Her to cut away, and will I hand it over?
3. Which of my four powers is most out of alignment: my sense of “I”, my mind, my senses, or my dealings with things? What one change would begin to align it?

A2.4 EVENING REVIEW: THREE LINES

Where I saw Her:

Where I forgot Her:

One thing for tomorrow:

Next classes and how to join

Join online via Zoom

Remote participants are welcome to attend online. **Please register on our website to receive the Zoom link: www.vedanta.nz/event-list**

The Hamilton Vedanta-Meditation class meets on the first Wednesday of the month, 6:30 to 8:00 pm, at Phoenix Community Hall, 22 Richmond St, Frankton. Remote participants may join online via Zoom after registering on the website.

E.1 SERIES REGISTER

Class no.	Date	Topic	Note
HVM-001	7 October 2026	Spiritualising Everyday Life: Niṣkāma Karma and Seva Yoga	
HVM-002	4 November 2026	The Divine Mother Kali: who She is, and our relationship with Her	This document
HVM-003	2 December 2026	To be announced	
HVM-004	6 January 2027	To be announced	

E.2 CONTACT

Swami Tadananda, Ramakrishna Vedanta Centre, 27 Arawa Street, New Lynn, Auckland, New Zealand. E: mail@vedanta.nz, www.vedanta.nz.

E.3 A CLOSING PRAYER

सर्वे भवन्तु सुखिनः सर्वे सन्तु निरामयाः ।
सर्वे भद्राणि पश्यन्तु मा कश्चिद्दुःखभाग्भवेत् ॥
ॐ शान्तिः शान्तिः शान्तिः

sarve bhavantu sukhinaḥ sarve santu nirāmayāḥ
sarve bhadrāṇi paśyantu mā kaścid duḥkha-bhāg bhavet
oṃ śāntiḥ śāntiḥ śāntiḥ

May all be happy. May all be free from illness. May all see what is auspicious. May no one suffer. Om, peace, peace, peace.